

FOURTH SERIES  
VOL. 131  
No. 17



TUESDAY  
3<sup>RD</sup> MARCH, 2026

## PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

---

### OFFICIAL REPORT

---

### CONTENTS

---

#### COMMUNICATION FROM THE PRESIDENT

Absence from Ghana — [Col. 2]

#### VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 3]

#### BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025 — [Col. 14]

#### MOTION—

Message on the State of the Nation, 2026 — [Col. 76]

#### ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 144]

---

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,  
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,  
Parliament House, Accra.*

*©2026 Parliament of Ghana.*

THE  
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC  
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Tuesday, 3<sup>rd</sup> March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,  
Parliament House, at 2:36 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,  
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE  
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

COMMUNICATION FROM THE  
PRESIDENT

**Absence from Ghana**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon  
Members, the item numbered 4, Message  
from His Excellency the President.

Hon Members, with your indulgence,  
I read:



REPUBLIC OF GHANA

*Jubilee House*

*The President*

27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026

Rt. Hon. Speaker,

**ABSENCE FROM GHANA**

In accordance with Article 59 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana, I write to formally notify you of my intention to travel outside the country on 1<sup>st</sup> March, 2026 to Arusha, Tanzania to participate in the 2026 Judicial Year of The African Court on Human and Peoples' Rights, scheduled to take place on Monday, 2<sup>nd</sup> March, 2026. I will return the same day.

In my absence, the Vice President, Professor Naana Jane Opoku-Agyemang, shall perform my functions in accordance with Article 60 (8) of the Constitution.

**JOHN DRAMANI MAHAMA**

**THE RT. HON. SPEAKER  
OFFICE OF PARLIAMENT  
PARLIAMENT HOUSE  
ACCRA**

cc: The Vice President  
Jubilee House  
Accra

The Chief of Staff  
Jubilee House  
Accra

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, thank you for listening. There is no Communication from the Speaker. We will move to take the item numbered 6, which is Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

## VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I hold in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026. Hon Members, we also have the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 26<sup>th</sup> February, 2026. With your indulgence, we start with Thursday, 26<sup>th</sup> February, 2026 and then we would look at that of Friday, 27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026.

Page 1...12—

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday 26<sup>th</sup> February—

**Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah:** Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 12, the item numbered 15 should rather read; “at 12 minutes after 3 o’clock in the afternoon” and not in the evening.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But what I have here it is the word “afternoon” that is written there. All right; it is written here as “in the forenoon.”

Table Office, take note.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 26<sup>th</sup> February, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Now, let us move to the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026.

Page 1...4—

Yes, Hon Member?

**Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, let the record reflect that the item numbered 147 on the page numbered 4, Mr John Abdulai Jinapor now has a doctorate degree and I am aware that he notified the Clerk’s Office.

So, if the record can reflect that—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, take note, if you have been written to. Yes, Hon Member?

Page 5, 6—

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, same prayer for the Member listed from item numbered 233, Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu. Apart from making that point on the Floor, he has also notified the Table Office.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, please take note if you have been notified.

Page 7—

Yes, Hon Member?

**Dr F. K. Asamoah:** Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 7, the item numbered 5, Dr Nana Ayew Afriye was present but he has been marked absent.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, take note.

Page 8, 9—

Yes, Hon Member?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** The page numbered 9, item numbered 9, line 4, after the word “to”, I believe it should read, “to witness the State of the Nation address by His Excellency the President.”

2:46 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, take note. Yes, Hon Member?

**Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 8; I seek your guidance on this. Under recognition of dignitaries, item numbered vii and xi, “Rightly so, Rt Hon Speaker acknowledged the presence of Rt Hon Prof Aaron Mike Oquaye and Mr Ekow Danquah Smith Buttey.” But they were not in the House on the day, though when the Speaker was making the official notification, he mentioned it.

So, I just want to seek your guidance in respect of this, that though they were acknowledged, they were not present on the day in the Chamber to listen to the Message on the State of the Nation.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table Office, take note. If he was not present, expunge his name.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Page 10, 11—

Yes, Hon Assafuah?

**Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah:** Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 10, the item numbered 12, with your guidance, “...Mr Mahama Ayariga took turns to make brief remarks on the Message delivered by H. E. the President.” Well, I do not know if my English is not right, but maybe with your guidance, I think that it should be “took his turn” or “took a turn.”

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I think grammatically it is correct.

**Mr Assafuah:** Mr Speaker, with respect, I would bring you back to page 4, item number 119, quickly, “Upper west Akim”, the “w” should be capital “W”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Page 4?

**Mr Assafuah:** Yes, page 4.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Please draw the Table’s attention to it, I may not go back to page 4.

**Mr Assafuah:** Mr Speaker, thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Page 11...13—

Yes, Hon Lukutor?

**Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor:** Mr Speaker, the page numbered 13, under xvi “Mr Emmanuel Koranteng”, there is “and” under his name. I am sure it should be “Principal Assistant Clerk, and Clerk to the Committee”. But “and”

is rather being placed under his name. I seek your guidance whether it should rather go to where he is being described.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, you said under xvi on page numbered 13, “Mr Emmanuel Koranteng”?

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** Yes, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** “Koranteng” here ends with “g”.

**Ing Surv Lukutor:** Yes, Mr Speaker. So, my submission is that there is the word “and” under his name, which rather should go under his description, “Principal Assistant Clerk, and Clerk to the Committee”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, so Table, take note of the formatting.

Page 14, 15—

Yes, Hon Dafeamekpor?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, on page number 15, the item numbered xiii, “Mr George Atta Boateng” has a Ph. D, so he should be “Dr”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Has he also notified the Clerk?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, no. He attended upon the Committee. It is a Committee meeting that has been advertised.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Mostly, it depends on how the

communication from the Committee was sent to the Clerks-at-the-Table. So, if that is the nature of the communication, then our *Votes and Proceedings* is not wrong.

Page 16, 17—

Yes, Hon Assafuah?

**Mr Assafuah:** Mr Speaker, on page number 17, item number 3, “In Attendance”, “Mr Geoffery Kini”—If we do a sharp comparison with what has been stated on the page numbered 4, the item numbered 149, the same name, there is a bit of distinction, and so if the Table can check—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table, take note.

Page 18...21—

Yes, Hon Assafuah?

**Mr Assafuah:** Mr Speaker, on page numbered 20, item numbered ix “Internal Audit”, has been spelt “Interal”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table, kindly take note.

Page 22...32?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026, as corrected is adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, let us move to the *Official Report* of Friday, 20<sup>th</sup> February,

2026. It is for your correction. Hon Members, any correction?

*[No correction was made to the Official Report of Friday, 20<sup>th</sup> February, 2026.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, with your indulgence, I acknowledge the students from Keta Senior High Technical School (KETASCO) where I did my A-levels. They are led by Mr Gbadago Prince Kwadzo, National Commission on Civic Education (NCCE) Patron, from Keta Constituency; they number 87.

*[Students of Keta Senior High Technical School were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We also have students from Oda Senior High School, ODASCO led by Mr Ronald Antwi Baafi, NCCE Patron. They are from Akim Oda Constituency, and they number 72.

*[Students of Oda Senior High School were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We have Classic Multimedia Institute, led by Prince Duodu, Chief Executive Officer. They are from Okaikwei North. They number 44.

*[Students of Classic Multimedia Institute were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We also have National Health Association of Ghana, led by Boateng Carter Lisbon.

They are from Effiduase/Asokore. They number 11.

*[Representatives of National Health Association of Ghana were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We have Bunso M/A Basic School, Bunso, led by Victus Amuzu, Headteacher. They are from Abuakwa South. They are 65 in number.

*[Students of Bunso M/A Basic School, Bunso were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** We have Nsakyie M/A Junior High School, led by Joy Kretsi, Headteacher. They are from Akuapem South. They number 70.

*[Students of Nsakyie M/A Junior High School were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome all of them to Parliament of Ghana and urge them to have a fruitful visit to Parliament.

Yes, Majority Leader?

**Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga):** Mr Speaker, the Minister for the Interior has something he wants to raise, so if we could indulge him.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, the application is to hear from the Minister for the Interior.

**First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu):** Mr Speaker, since we

do not know what the Minister has to say, I do not know the kind of application the Majority Leader is talking about because we have no idea what he is going to say, so we may listen to him.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

2:56 p.m.

## STATEMENT

### Complaint of Contempt

**Minister for the Interior (Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka):** Mr Speaker, thank you.

*[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker.]*

*[Refer to Column 4 of the Official Report of Wednesday, 4<sup>th</sup> March, 2026.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I crave your indulgence for us to vary the order of Business and continue with the Consideration Stage of the Securities and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025. We discussed that in Conclave. I believe that we will take a few clauses and then we can get back to the debate on the Message on the State of the Nation.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Minority, that is the application.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, at Conclave, I did indicate to the Majority

Leader that I disagree with this arrangement for us to take the Bill before even looking at Questions and debate on the Message on the State of the Nation. The President addressed the nation on Friday. Ghanaians want to hear our contributions as the people's representatives. I told him I disagreed, but I do not know on what basis he still insists that we should do the Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025. The President's Message on the State of the Nation is important because a lot of things have been said. To the extent that 7,800 birds are distributed to 13,000 farmers. To the extent that 1 million jobs have been created and fact checks are saying it is not true. Even Mr John Dumelo, who is the Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture, knows that they cannot share 7800 birds to 13,000 farmers.

So, Mr Speaker, we disagree with the application of the Majority Leader that we should do the Bill; we are not in agreement with it. We should go by the order of Business for the day. The Minister for the Interior is here and there are Questions for him to answer. He is capable of answering the questions. So, the Minister for the Interior should answer those questions before the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, honesty is the best policy. The truth shall make all of us free. At Conclave, there was no issue or question agreed upon. Two things happened. The pending Bills and the Message on the State of the Nation. Those in Conclave will even attest to the fact that there was a suggestion that by 6 o'clock p.m.,



everybody would have closed from work and be glued to the television and at that time, it would be good if we begin. I am saying what happened at Conclave and that is why I said that honesty is the best policy. The truth shall make all of us free. I personally would not like a situation where there would be an agreement involving me at Conclave, then we come here and do another thing. So, there was no issue of Question. In fact, in the previous weeks, we did Questions and Statements with no Government Business. It was on the basis of that that today at Conclave, you agreed to do the Message on the State of the Nation and the Bills. So, if that is the agreement, what wrong has the Majority Leader done starting with the Bill?

Hon Members, before coming to the Consideration Stage of the Bill, permit me to acknowledge the presence of a 10-member delegation comprising staff and participants from the United States Air War College who are in Ghana on an international study tour as part of their Air War students and instructors cohort educational visits from 1<sup>st</sup> to 8<sup>th</sup> March, 2026.

3:56 p.m.

The study tour aims to expose participants to key national security, governance and strategic issues in Ghana and the wider African region. The delegation is engaging Parliament to better understand Ghana's democratic governance system and civil-military relations. Overall, the engagement seeks to strengthen mutual understanding and

enhance cooperation between Ghana and the United States of America. The members of the delegation are, Col Amanda Watkins (Class Leader); Dr Scott Edmondson, Instructor; Col Justin Noehl, Chaplain (Lt Col) Bitrus Cobong; Lt Col Tyler Royster; Lt Col Hillary Hedberg; Lt Col Lenora Alva; Lt Col Jonathan Gardner; Lt Col Kenneth Smith, and Mr Leonard Goolsby.

Hon Members, on behalf of the House, I welcome the delegation to Parliament and I wish them a fruitful deliberation.

*[Delegation from the United States Air War College were acknowledged.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Now, Securities and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025 at the Consideration Stage.

## **BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE**

### **Security and Intelligence Agencies Bill, 2025**

Clause 5 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 6 — Establishment of Regional and District Security Councils

**Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, *add* the following new subclauses:

“(#) A regional or district security council shall perform its functions impartially and shall not act on partisan political instructions.

(#) In the performance of its functions, a regional or district security council

shall have due regard to the fundamental human rights and freedoms guaranteed under Chapter 5 of the Constitution.”

Mr Speaker, the justification to this is simply that at the regional level, the Regional Security Coordinator appointed is a partisan appointee. We are aware of the abuse of rights often where those who occupy that position feel partisanly entitled. There are several instances where the Coordinator would have to intervene or the Minister for National Security would have to intervene just because some Regional Security Coordinators are acting so unprofessionally in one way or the other. Mr Speaker, this Legislation will further be a deterrence and enshrine in law what the 1992 Constitution already guarantees in Chapter 5.

When dealing with matters of National Security, impartiality brings certainty and assurance to the public. It should be a body that at all levels, it does not matter one's partisan interests, must have confidence in them. If at the Head Office, the National Security Secretariat, citizens are assured that these are professionals at work, then it follows that at the regional and district level, those who are put there to be in charge of security, even if they are partisanly appointed, would appreciate the fact that, by law, they cannot disregard the rights of citizens and that they cannot abuse such powers. If they do, such conduct would have consequences.

Mr Speaker, having given this elaborate explanation as the rationale

behind these two proposals, I would want to rest my case and pray that Hon Members would also have a bite on this proposal. Mr Speaker, thank you very much indeed.

**Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza:** Mr Speaker, I clearly understand the point being made by the Hon Minority Leader. Indeed, issues about security on the minds of Ghanaians is twofold: one which is to protect, and one which is the abuse of it. So, I can understand his attempt to put something in law to say that once we do this, this would cure the mischief. Mr Speaker, but he does not need to do that. I can understand.

4:06 p.m.

In 2017, I had my own experience where a certain regional level security operator ordered that the entire town of Adaklu Kodiabe be raided. For three days, they searched the rooms of all those who were government workers, to find out whether anyone was keeping things that belonged to government during the transition. Of course, that did not end anywhere. The Regional Minister at the time did the right thing and suspended that particular so-called security coordinator for a period of time before he got his job back.

Mr Speaker, the two introductions made by the Minority Leader here are covered by one law or the other in our Constitution. I do not see the point of saying that, subclause (a), “a regional or district security council, shall perform the functions impartially”.

Mr Speaker, of course, by the time they are taking their oaths, it would state how they are supposed to do their work. Then subclause (2), which reads:

“...in the performance of its function, a regional or district security council shall have due regard to the fundamental human rights and freedoms guaranteed under Chapter 5 of the Constitution.”

He has already mentioned Chapter 5 of the Constitution. He does need to lift it into a law like this.

Mr Speaker, the idea is all right, but this is the just a repetition of things that exist in one law or other. In fact, he must as well say the same thing within all the clauses. He buttressed his point by talking about the fact that the district and the regional Ministers are political appointees. Of course, Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) is also appointed by the President, though they rise through the ranks to get to wherever they are.

The Inspector General of Police (IGP) is appointed by the President. In that case, would he say that because it is being appointed by the President, he is politically tainted? I do not think that we need to begin to do this. Because you can lift the two things he said and put it in all the clauses; it would just make the Bill voluminous; it would not serve anything. It is the conscience of the people operating in this office, who know that there are laws in this country that expect them to work professionally within the framework of the Constitution.

If the Minority Leader was here, I would have asked him to probably abandon this particular proposal because it does not materially add anything to the principles of the Bill.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister for the Interior?

**Alhaji Mohammed-Mubarak Muntaka:** Thank you very much. Mr Speaker, the amendment is not necessary. This is because, his fear has been taken care of in clause 15. But let me read it so the Hon Members will be sure that that has been taken care of.

In clause 15 (j), it is stated that as part of the financial of the national security coordinator;

“ensure that all activities of the national security and the intelligence agencies are carried out in compliance with the laws of Ghana and accepted principles of public international law.”

Mr Speaker, that is adequately provided in our Constitution and others. We should also remember that all this is guided by the Constitution. Even though the Minority Leader is not here, this amendment is not necessary and has been taken care of. So, maybe we should just put it to a vote and make progress.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Rev John Ntim Fordjour?

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour:** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to support the amendment proposed in clause 6, that these two provisions be added, that; “the Regional or District Security Council shall perform its functions impartially and shall not act in partisan political considerations or instructions.”

That provision even supports the argument just made by the Hon Minister for the Interior, citing the functions of the National Security Coordinator and even specific reference made to function (j), which is

“...ensure that all activities of the national security and intelligence agencies are carried out in compliance with the laws of Ghana and accepted principles of public international law.”

So, this specific provision being proposed in clause 6, gives it clarity and lays the bedrock and sets the standard of non-partisan considerations in the exercise of the functions of the Regional Security Councils (REGSECs) and the District Security Councils (DISECs), which later on, in the coordinating function of the Office of the National Security Coordinator, he would then now have the responsibility to ensure that that standard is in compliance.

Mr Speaker, with the consistency of principles, it will serve this legislation well and better if the amendments are upheld.

I thank you.

*Question put and amendment negatived.*

Clause 6 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 7 — Membership of Regional Security Council

**Mr First Speaker:** Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

**Chairperson of the Committee (Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings):** Mr Speaker, I beg to move subclause (1), paragraph (c), *delete and insert* as follows: “(c)the District Chief Executives of the District Assemblies in the regional capital as the Council may determine;”.

The reason for this being that the regional capital may have more than one district assembly. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, it is for your consideration. Any further amendment? Hon Members, in the absence of any further proposed amendment, I will put a question—Yes, Hon Member?

**Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah:** With the greatest of respect, I want to propose a further amendment to clause 7(c).

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, you have arrested me putting the question on clause 7(c). Please, let us follow the proceedings.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairperson of the Committee, the item numbered (iii)?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** I beg to move subclause (1), paragraph (i), *delete*.

*Question put amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, the item numbered (iv)?

Hon Members, at least follow and vote. Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, subclause (1), after paragraph (n), *add* the following new paragraph: “(h) the officer in charge of the National Signals Bureau in the region;”.

4:16 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the proposed amendment is for your consideration. Any further amendments? In the absence of any further amendments, I will put the question.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 7 (1)(n) as amended is ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Chairperson of the Committee, propose amendment (v) at page 19.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, sub-clause 1, *delete* paragraph (o).

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The proposal is to delete paragraph (o). It is for your consideration. Any further amendments?

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Chairperson of the Committee, (vi) —

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, respectfully, notwithstanding your ruling, you did not see me when I rose—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well, I can relax the rules.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, thank you very much. Mr Speaker, I understand my Chairperson wants the Director of the National Identification Authority (NIA) removed as a member of the Council.

Mr Speaker, we are at the age where human identification, its movement, tracking and verification of such is extremely important. Therefore, collaboration and cooperation at the regional and district levels—If we are putting together a security architecture it will not hurt if the officer in charge in the region and district is part of that body. I

pray that my Chairperson considers this position and lets us include a National Identification Authority at least at the regional and district level as part of the Committee.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Must they be a member in order to collaborate? The other agencies that the NIA is collaborating with, are they members of their boards and councils?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, in today's world, every transaction that we do and especially tomorrow will require the intervention of the NIA. Today, we cannot withdraw money from a bank without consulting the NIA.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, that is why I am asking that. Your assertion is correct but do they serve on the board of the banks or the banks who collaborate with them to be able to do that?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, look at the composition of the members of the Regional Security Council. We have the National Ambulance Service, we have the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO), Ghana National Fire Service but I am not downgrading their importance. But we are talking about national identification, which in terms of security today, ranks very high in the architecture of our council.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

Before the Chair— Yes, Hon Bedzrah?

**Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah:** Mr Speaker, thank you. I thought my Hon Colleague is a member of the Committee on Security and Intelligence and this argument will be advanced at that committee level, not for us to bring it back again. I do not know whether he made this argument at the Committee level or not.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Bedzrah, there is a principle in our hands that is called the “Bagbin Principle”. If you raise a matter at the Committee and they have not agreed on it, there is no rule of the House that prevents you from raising it at Plenary.

**Mr Bedzrah:** Mr Speaker, I just want to find out from the Chairperson, will it offend anything if the NIA representative is on the board or the committee? If not, why are they removing it?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Agbodza?

**Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza:** Mr Speaker, thank you. Hon Bryan Acheampong welcome back. You put up a good fight. *[Laughter]* You have done very well because I have been looking for him to congratulate him and I have not seen him. This is the first time. Allow me to just congratulate my Hon Colleague.

Mr Speaker, he has also made a very good point. In today's world, data is more sensitive than even having a handgun in the hands of somebody. The point he made is very reasonable. I

would defer to the Chairperson to consider whether we could actually reinstate that particular point. Because if we know what data means today, we should be worried about who has access to your data. It is probably more sensitive than maybe the Fire Service when there is fire. But on a daily basis, the guy who has got access to your data is much more sensitive.

So, I would maybe encourage the Chairperson to reconsider.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, we would abandon that proposal. The fact of the matter is we are hoping that the NIA will be realigned as a security service at some point in order to make sure that all staff are properly vetted and trained to actually be at the level that is required for the kind of data that they have oversight of. So, we would abandon that proposal and maintain the NIA as a membership of the committee.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. The proposed amendment to subclause 1(o) is accordingly abandoned.

Item (vi), Chairperson of the Committee?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, the proposed amendment is for subclause 1 paragraph (p) to be *deleted*.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The proposal is to delete subclause 1 (p). Any further amendments?

Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I would like to know if the Chairperson can give clarity to 7(1) (q). “Three members of Parliament from the region nominated by the Regional Minister;”—  
[*Interruption*]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, I keep on saying that if there is an amendment on the Floor, we have to finish dealing with that amendment before any other issue is raised. Now do we leave what is under consideration to consider the matter that you have raised?

Hon Members, the proposed amendment has to do with (p).

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, if we listen to Hon Bryan Acheampong’s proposal, it is the same thing that he advanced. So National Ambulance Service also plays a critical role in our state’s architecture. So, what is the point in deleting the National Ambulance Service?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** If you look at the other membership, they connote some security in nature. But these two that are being proposed to be deleted are not. That is the basis for which they are deleting the NIA and then the ambulance service.

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, no. Hon Habib Iddrisu is saying that the Ambulance Service is more medical but when we put in place the security architecture, they are always part of it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why at the Committee level it was proposed that these two be deleted. I was at the Committee meeting and it was proposed that the two, that is the NIA and then the National Ambulance Service should be deleted. I believe Hon Ntim Fordjour was at the meeting.

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** If we abandon that of NIA, so be it that we should also maintain the National Ambulance Service. If you listen carefully, they will say that when they need them, they will be invited. Then what is the point?

4:26 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, they need not be on the board. But when you need them, you can invite them. The same thing applies to National Identification Authority.

If you look at the membership, it is very elaborate. But once you have decided to serve the (o), the argument is that you serve the (p) as well.

**Rev Ntim Fordjour:** On the consideration of whether or not we should include NIA, as a member on the Regional Security Councils (REGSEC), a number of deliberations went in. We even received proposals from NIA. They persuaded the Committee as to why it is essential for us to include them. The decision we took then was to defer it to Plenary, so that we gauge the sentiment of Plenary. So far, we have seen forceful arguments in favour that we maintain NIA in the

provision which we support, so NIA must be maintained.

However, the proposal for National Ambulance Service to be included is problematic because we are drawing the composition of the REGSEC and the District Security Council (DISEC) from Article 83 of the Constitution. The guidance of the national security architecture is already provided for in Article 83. We do not want to introduce strenuous institutions onto the councils at the district and regional levels, particularly non-essential security institutions. We are not persuaded that as essential as National Ambulance Services are medically, it is not essential intelligence-wise and security-wise, for which we propose that it be deleted. As and when a matter relates to the inclusion of Ambulance Service, they may be invited.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, I agree with you. If you look at Article 83 (1), it is the President, the Vice-President, the Ministers for the time being holding the portfolio, then it mentions the portfolio, the Chief of Defence Staff, the Inspector General of Police, the Director-General of Prisons Service, the Director of External Intelligence, the Director of Internal Intelligence, the Director of Military Intelligence, the Commissioner of Customs, Excise and Preventive Service, and three persons appointed by the President.

So, if you look at all these, you will realise that they are of security in nature. That is a constitutional



composition. That was what informed the argument to *delete* the NIA and the National Ambulance Service.

**Mr Agbodza:** Mr Speaker, what you read is right. But that was before today's data world. Parliament did not stop last year. We are here today because we can improve laws that were made yesterday. To NIA, we have already decided to stay.

The mischief he is trying to cure is already cured in—If we are to allow the Chairperson to go to the item numbered 20 (viii), which is an attempt to create an auxiliary clause that says that, if need be, the rest of the people who are not essential security staff can be co-opted to participate in any deliberation, so that we do not add people here who are not necessarily day-to-day security agencies.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, the argument that we are making goes for the NIA as well, so that when NIA is needed, they could also be brought in. But if you look at the composition, today if they say gather security intelligence in the country, we will gather them minus NIA, meanwhile, their services are so invaluable.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, currently NIA participates in joint intelligence committee sittings. That is part of the reason the Committee is not against the inclusion of the regional and district level, especially given the central role that the NIA plays in all activities, including identification of persons who may cross our borders.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, they are saying in the same vein, drop the amendment for clause 7 (p) as well.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** However, Mr Speaker, National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO) being a member takes care of the National Ambulance Service in the event of any kind of situation occurring. So, if need be, the National Ambulance Service can be co-opted, but NADMO does take care of that as part of the central coordination organisation.

Furthermore, Mr Speaker, the concern around the membership at the regional level is the size. As it gets bigger with membership that is not considered core, their decision-making capacity may be reduced, given what their needs may be. That is why if we proceed to the next amendment proposed, the House will find that we have proposed that the chair of the REGSEC may co-opt members as and when required.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Amendment proposed, after subclause (2), *insert* the following subclauses:

“(3) The chairperson of a regional security council may, in consultation with the regional security council, invite such other persons—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Chairperson, you have to move the item numbered 20 (vii).

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** I beg your pardon.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Clause 7 (q).

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Amendment proposed - Subclause (1), paragraphs (q), *delete*.

4:36 p.m.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, I rise to support the proposed amendment that would *delete* that clause, which proposes the inclusion of Members of Parliament, as a matter of fact, three Members of Parliament on REGSEC.

We have already established the principle that we expect National Security Council and their committees at all levels to operate on principles of non-partisan considerations. We want to depoliticise the REGSEC as much as possible.

So, when we create a situation where we give the chairperson of REGSEC an opportunity to appoint three Members of Parliament within the region, on to the Council; it is problematic. More so, when in matters of security, it is even in the interest of the Member of Parliament that he should not get involved in DISEC and REGSEC matters. Particularly, when we know that 90 per cent of issues that relate to the jurisdiction of REGSEC and DISEC are chieftaincy in nature,

where it must even be in the interest of the Member of Parliament to maintain their neutrality. It would be inimical for us. So, we should delete that.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I also want to add my voice to read that it should be deleted, because looking at the composition, nobody is in any elected political office, so it should be deleted —

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, if we are advancing an argument, let us be careful that Members of Parliament are politicians; they are political animals. The President, who has been voted for, is the Commander-in-Chief of the Ghana Armed Forces; he is a politician. So, what are we talking about here?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, do you not think you will be causing harm to yourself?

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Everybody in this country is a political animal, including pastors. We have a Reverend Minister who is a politician sitting down there.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Richard Acheampong, there is a chieftaincy dispute in your region, and you are invited to come and serve on the Council.

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** As Members of Parliament, we will be informed of anything that happens in the constituency. We are aware of what is happening.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, after subclause (2), *insert* the following subclauses:

“(3) The chairperson of a regional security council may, in consultation with the regional security council, invite such other persons as the chairperson considers necessary for any deliberations of the regional security council.

(4) A person invited to participate in the deliberations of the regional security council under subsection (3) shall not vote on a matter for decision before the regional security council.”

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 7 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 8 — Functions of Regional Security Council

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, opening phrase, *delete* “in relation to the region” and *insert* “perform the following functions relating to the region concerned:”.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 8 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 9 — Membership of the District Security Council

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, subclause (1), paragraph (h), *delete*.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Yes, Hon Bedzrah?

**Mr Bedzrah:** Mr Speaker, I am wondering why the head of Customs in the district will be deleted from the District Security Council.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** It was also removed at the regional level. Mr Speaker, that is because the original rendition had the head of Customs; we now have the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA), and as a result of it being a division of GRA, we just felt it would be better to.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, Article 83 of the 1992 Constitution makes provision for the Commissioner of Customs as part of the National Security Council. Some of the hotspots that we have in this country are the border communities, and it is the customs officials who deal with the security challenges with the officials of the Ghana Immigration Service at these hotspots.

It may not be a challenge in the majority of the districts in the country, but for our border communities, it is imperative that the Customs Division of

GRA is made part of the District Security Council, not by co-option, but as members of the committee.

Respectfully, Mr Speaker, if we cannot go back to their membership as part of the Regional Security Council, but for the District Security Councils, especially for our border communities, the Customs Divisions cannot be made a co-opted member, but a member of that committee. I respectfully ask my Chairperson to reconsider this position.

Thank you very much.

**Mr Bedzrah:** Mr Speaker, let me add to what my Colleague from the ECOWAS Parliament just mentioned, that the Customs officers in our districts hold arms, even though we say they are not—they bear arms. Therefore, if somebody bears arms, we know what ammunition can do to an individual. So, I want to ask the Chairperson and the Ranking Member to just allow them to be at least part of the district council. Thank you.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, indeed, in terms of Article 83 of the 1992 Constitution, if we take out Customs, it means we are amending the 1992 Constitution by legislation. So, we must be guided. I want to plead that we have it stand down, so that we can make progress.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Why stand it down? Chairperson of the Committee, what is your view? The 1992 Constitutional frame has the Custom and Preventive Services. So, why are you

deleting it at the district or the regional level? Yes?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Respectfully, Mr Speakeer, the Security Council provision on Article 83 of the 1992 Constitution is not what we seek to amend. What we seek to do will not be in violation of Article 83. We are establishing committees of the National Security Council, which committees do not necessarily have to relate to what—*[Interruption]*. Not necessarily. We are setting up a committee, and that is very different from what Article 83 stands for.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes. Taking that into consideration, why the need to exempt the head of Customs?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Yes, and I appreciate the support. What I am only diverging is to step it down at the moment. I think that we can let it—We will take a decision on it and let the Customs Division pass as part of the District Security Council.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Rockson Dafeamekpor, the Minister is here. Let us hear from the Minister so that we do not defer the clause.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** I am only proposing a step down because we took it out of the regional committee as well. That is why I thought that when we have this stood down, we will be able to come —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Was it taken from the regional committee?

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Yes, which we considered earlier. Once we can do that, why not make progress?

**Alhaji Muntaka:** Well, Mr Speaker, I must say that this is the Bill I brought. That has all these in there, and there are reasons, because at the regional level, you are concerned about tax collection and the activities of the Customs Services.

But the wisdom of the Committee was that the composition was too large, and they wanted to do away with some of the members. As Minister, who am I to challenge what Parliament wants to do? I remember during the meeting of the Committee, I told them that there were reasons to bring all this, and this Bill, if you would remember, Mr Speaker, did not go through an Executive approval. So, what I am saying is that if Members now want to change their mind and have them, that is better for us because that is what we wanted. But it must then reflect the region, since the Consideration Stage is flexible.

4:46 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, do we go back to reinstate it at the regional level as well? Very well. Should I put a Question on it, or you want to abandon it?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, we will abandon the proposal to have the Customs, Excise and Preventive Service removed from the committee.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Then, Hon Members, let us go back and have it reinstated in the “Composition of the Regional Security Council”. That is clause 7(i).

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, that is correct. It is subclause (iii).

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, that is clause 7(i) at page 18 of the *Order Paper*, amendment numbered iii.

Chairperson of the Committee, may you move accordingly so that we can reinstate it and move forward. You are hereby granted leave to do so.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

We would like to abandon the proposal to have the deletion of “the Head of Customs Division of the Ghana Revenue Authority in charge of the region” reinstated.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the earlier Question put is hereby rescinded. The proposal is to abandon amendment (iii), that is 7(1)(i).

Hon Members, the proposed amendment is abandoned.

Can we move forward to clause 9, that is, amendment xi. Yes, Hon Bedzrah?

**Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah:** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, since we are on clause 7(1)(c),

“the District Chief Executive of the District Assembly in the regional capital as the Council may determine;”.

Mr Speaker, if you have the DCE or MCE being the head of Municipal Security Council (MUSEC) in the regional capital, the same person coming up to Regional Security Council (REGSEC), it does not make it any tidier. I think that they should be moved if the numbers are too great. Let us move the DCE or MCE from the REGSEC and make them head their DISEC or MUSEC so that we can have a smaller number than what we have here. They cannot be members of REGSEC and at the same time, MUSEC or DISEC. I do not think it is the best, Mr Speaker. So, I want to propose that we delete—

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, maybe my Colleague is getting it all wrong. The Chief Executive at the regional capital is not from the constituency. He is there just to coordinate the affairs at the regional level, because he lives in the region. If he is coming from the district level, then I would agree with you. But he is at the regional capital so he has to give briefings to the committee.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister for the Interior.?

**Alhaji Muntaka:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The reason we have the Mayors or MCEs sitting at the regional capital is— Let us look at the nature of Accra. The

Regional Minister is only effective as long as they coordinate very effectively with the DCEs. In fact, the districts are more resourceful than the region. For example, the Mayor of Accra is more resourceful than the Regional Minister. The Mayor of Kumasi is more resourceful than the Regional Minister. So, their presence at the Regional Security Council, when there are challenges that need to be dealt with swiftly, is essential.

Because of the nature of the districts that we have—So, we realise that Accra it is beyond Accra Metropolitan Assembly (AMA). We have Ledzokuku Municipal Assembly and we have La-Nkwatanang Municipal Assembly and others. They are all within the Accra enclave. That is why we have to allow the Council to nominate those who should be representing the immediate districts within the capital at the Regional Security Council, so that their collaboration and activities will be well-coordinated. That is the essence of this.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, if we look at this law carefully, and relate it to Security and Intelligence Agencies Act, 1996 (Act 526) and Security and Intelligence Agencies Act, 2020 (Act 1030), the only area where we have a major amendment is to do away with Minister for National Security as well as the functions of the Minister for National Security.

So, if you look at clause 6(c) of Act 1030, the District Chief Executive is there, that is, the regional level; you look at clause 8(a), the District Chief

Executive is still there. And these are the laws that served us for several years without any problem. So, it is just a repetition of the *status quo* which we have lived with. So, unless we have a strong reason, I plead that we do not depart from it.

Yes, Hon Bryan Acheampong?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Thank you, Mr Speaker.

You are very right, and for my many years in this Chamber, perhaps this is the first time I would disagree with the former Chief Whip and now Minister.

Mr Speaker, the issue of the Mayor of Kumasi being a member of the Regional Security Council in matters unrelated to Kumasi Metropolitan Assembly (KMA) is of no relevance. If we are discussing issues of Asante Bekwai, what is the relevance of the Mayor of KMA sitting there? In any case, we are not asking them to fund the security situation in Bekwai.

If there is an issue in Nalerigu or Bawku, it is not the Mayor of Tamale, because of the resources that he is able to generate, fund the situation in Bawku. If the matter is related to his jurisdiction, then that Mayor can and should be invited. What we are trying to do is to create space to allow for Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) to be invited to the Regional Security Council where the matter relates to that particular assembly.

Mr Speaker, this Bill seeks to cure the challenges that we have with Act 526 and Act 1030. It is not many things that are in both Acts that are pure and clear. So, Mr Speaker, respectfully, if you can grant us permission to introduce some of these amendments, especially, when 7(c) has already been passed, if you grant leave, that provision as being suggested by Hon Bedzrah should be looked at and removed so that it creates space for other MMDCEs to be invited to REGSEC if there is a need related to their jurisdiction.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Bedzrah?

**Mr Bedzrah:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. With your pleasure, I want to move that clause 7(1)(c) be deleted from the Bill.

Thank you.

4:56 p.m.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The proposal is to *delete* clause 7(1)(c).

Yes, Hon Suhuyini?

**Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan:** Mr Speaker, I wish to support the proposal that has been moved by my Hon Senior Colleague, Hon Bedzrah. Mr Speaker, I think that when we are making these laws, we should be cautious about giving institutions or bodies discretion, because we all know that discretion can be subject to abuse.

So, when we make a proposal that because we have a number of districts, I mean, there is no question about the importance of a district assembly chief executive being part of these set-ups. There is no question about that. But when we make the choice of who represents the rest of the assemblies at the discretion of the Council, we leave room for possible abuse someday.

But when we set a criterion and I agree with what Hon Bryan Acheampong said that if the aim is to have assemblies represented, then we should be looking at a criterion that will allow assemblies to, even if it has to be as and when, be part of the Council, then we do so with a laid-down criteria of how one gets to be part of it. But when we say that the Council will choose who becomes part of it, then we leave room for lobbying and discretion which could be abused. So, I agree that we should—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, have you looked at the rendition that we are trying to delete?

**Alhaji S. S. Alhassan:** Yes, I have.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** It says the District Chief Executive of the district assembly in the regional capital. That is the rendition.

**Alhaji S. S. Alhassan:** Yes, Mr Speaker, and when the Hon Minister for the Interior was giving the explanation, he used Accra as an example. And I can also use my own district as an example. If you go to Tamale, we have two different districts. So, in that case, are the

two going to be part? And if the two are part, what business do they have when an issue concerns, for instance Yendi district? If the two are representing districts in the Northern Region and they are part because they come from the capital, how will an issue in Yendi or Saboba concern them?

But if we want assemblies, which should be the ideal situation, represented, then we should have a criterion that would allow the Council to, as and when necessary, perhaps invite whichever assembly they deem fit because of a subject matter that is being discussed to be part of it. I thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, I will put a question on the proposed amendment.

Yes, Hon Anyimadu-Antwi, I have not heard you the whole day.

**Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I have not heard from the Chairperson on this proposal. This argument came up at the Committee level and the Minister explained as he had explained. And the strongest point he had given was that if one is looking at Regional Security Council, one cannot go without the Kumasi Metropolitan Assembly (KMA) boss and vice versa, for the Greater Accra. But on the Floor, I hear very strong arguments. This came up, but I pray and urge the Chairperson that because we do not have any principle guiding this, he yields to this stronger argument. Thank you, Mr Speaker.



**Alhaji Muntaka:** Well, I just want to draw my Colleagues' attention that the council we are talking about here is the National Security Council that is chaired by the President. *[Interruption]* No, we are talking about the Council here. We are talking about the Council and that was what we agreed at the Committee. That when we talk about the district chief executive of the district assembly in the regional capital, as the Council may determine, we are talking about the National Security Council, which is chaired by the President.

So, Colleagues, yes, I can see the challenge of — *[Interruption]* No, we are saying that those who serve on that have to be selected by the National Security Council, not the Regional Security Council. When you talk about Council here, we are referring to the National Security Council. You can see that at the interpretation, if you want it to be Regional Security Council, you state it so. If you want it to be District Security Council, you state it so. But when we say Council in this Bill, we are talking about the National Security Council that is chaired by the President. Let us be careful.

Hon Bryan has worked in this space and he has been a Minister before. Even as the Minister in charge of Security, he knows how important the National Security Coordinator is when it comes to resources. And you do not want to make a move without coming along with your National Security Council. Believe me, in all these regions, without the Mayors or the DCEs in the capital, the Regional Minister will not be able to function and

that is a fact. Anybody who has been a Regional Minister here will attest to that fact and know how they operate. So, any attempt to remove this will be simply cutting their supply line and I want to urge the House not to do that. Just leave it. They have been managing it since 1993 till now so let us keep it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, my main point is that, in (Act 1026), this has been the structure and we have lived with it for several years, without any problem. We caused an amendment to (Act 1026), and we now have (Act 1030). That is the provision in (Act 1030), and we have also lived with it and the current Bill is not seeking to amend those things.

The only thing that it is seeking to amend is the creation of the Security Minister and their functions. So, why are we causing this trouble to ourselves, going to amend the existing law, which this one is not seeking to amend? It is a new law, all right but if a provision of a Bill has served you for several years without any problem, you should have a strong reason to cause it to be amended.

**Mr Bedzrah:** Mr Speaker, I would want to abandon my proposal because the Minister is speaking *Hausa*, and he is fasting. *[Laughter]* He says that he wants to go and break his fast, so I have abandoned my proposal.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, then I would put the question on the entire clause<sup>7</sup>.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 7 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Now, we are moving to Clause 9, (xi).

Chairperson of the Committee?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, Subclause (1), after paragraph (m), *insert* new paragraph as follows: “(n) the officer in charge of the National Signals Bureau in the district;”.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Chairperson, take into consideration the consequential amendments proposed that were dropped.

Let us move to (xii).

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, we would like to abandon the proposal to have (n) deleted.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Accordingly, abandoned. Yes, let us move to (xiii).

5:06 p.m.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, *delete* Subclause (1), paragraph (o).

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, (xiv)?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, *delete*, Subclause (1), paragraph (p).

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, (xv).

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, *delete* Subclause (1), paragraph (q). However, Mr Speaker, there is a concern about the fact that the Bill makes provision for at least one woman.

We would like to maintain that, as international best practice says, as part of security, we should always consider the gender dimension.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, you want to abandon the amendment?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Yes, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the proposed amendment is abandoned while the provision is hereby ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Yes, Dr Kabiru?

**Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama:** Mr Speaker, do I get the sense that the Committee is proposing to abandon the proposed amendment to (q), which states that:

“Three other persons shall be appointed by the Chairperson of the Council, at least one of whom is a woman and another, a community leader in the district, with knowledge in human security”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Exactly so. You heard it loud and clear.

**Dr A. K. T. Mahama:** That is not what I am getting from the Chairperson.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is exactly what the Chairperson is saying. The proposed amendment is abandoned; therefore, the provision stands as part of the clause.

Chairperson of the Committee, (xvi)?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, amendment proposed - After subclause (2), insert the following subclauses:

“(#) The Chairperson may, in consultation with the district security council, invite such other persons as the Chairperson considers necessary for any deliberations of the district security council.”

(#) A person invited to participate in the deliberations of the district security council under subsection (3) shall not vote on a matter for decision before the regional security council.”

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 9 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 10—Functions of the district security council.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, amendment proposed - Line 1, *delete* “in relation to the district” and *insert* “perform the following functions relating to the district concerned:”,

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 10 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 11—Ministerial responsibility for national security.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, amendment proposed - subclause (2), paragraph (a), *delete* and *insert* the following:

“(a) within one year after the inauguration of a new Parliament, submit to Parliament a reviewed coordinated National Security Policy and Strategy approved by the Council;”

*Question put and amended agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well, let us do the item numbered xix.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, amendment proposed - subclause (2), paragraph (c), *delete* and *insert* the following: “(c) perform any other function that the President may, in consultation with the Council, assign.”

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, the item numbered xx, and it stands in the name of Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour** *on behalf of Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah:* Mr Speaker, amendment proposed — subclause (2), paragraph (c), *delete*.

The rationale behind this is that the principle within the policy espoused by the sponsors is that they intend that the Minister who will have the responsibility for national security is a Minister who will have the original jurisdiction with national security and intelligence becoming an additional responsibility. And for that reason, in line with best practice, it is not proper to expand the functions beyond the two already stated, beyond submitting the reviewed coordinated national security policy and strategy within a year and beyond submitting reports to Parliament for the purpose of Parliamentary oversight. If we want to add—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Is it not the case that what you are seeking to be deleted has been deleted and a new one inserted, which says “perform any other function that the President may, in consultation with the council, assign”. Look at the proposed amendment in the item numbered xix.

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, in light of that, the amendment is accordingly abandoned.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, I am not too sure if you have seen Clause 11. But this whole provision, “The President shall assign ministerial responsibility for national security to a Minister whom the President considers appropriate”.

Does it mean that at all times, the President is bound to only assign ministerial responsibility, when it comes to national security, to a Minister and that the President cannot appoint a Minister?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Which other provisions are you reading?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, Clause 11 (1), are we saying that the President cannot appoint a Minister for national security? But if the President has the power to appoint Minister for National Security, then why are we in this Bill saying that the President shall assign ministerial responsibility for national security to a Minister?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** In this country, all Ministers are assigned responsibility.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, it says here, “to a Minister”. It means that it can be a Minister for Finance, or a Minister for the Interior.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes. It can be a Minister appointed by the President. So, there is nothing wrong with it.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, it is important to understand the historical background of this Bill and the context in which the Bill is being crafted. If we go to Article 83, it says that

“There shall be a National Security Council which shall consist of –

- a. the President;
- b. the Vice-President;
- c. the Ministers for the time being holding the portfolios of foreign affairs, defence, interior, and finance and such other Ministers as the President may determine;”

So, this Council is made up of several ministers. Now, I hear people say there should be a Minister for National Security. The Minister for Foreign Affairs performs national security functions. The Minister for Defence performs national security functions. The Minister for the Interior performs national security functions. And now, given that some development issues are security issues, the Minister for Finance performs national security functions.

Mr Speaker, for instance, if a Member of Parliament should ask a Question about national security, but that question is on national security but foreign affairs-related, the President should be able to assign the Minister for Foreign Affairs to answer those Questions, because it is within the Minister’s domain. There are national security issues outside the country, but it is within the Minister’s domain. In the same way, the Minister

for the Interior can be assigned by the President to answer those Questions.

The original idea behind assigning ministerial responsibility is that any of them could be asked by the President at any time to go and deal with a matter that he feels relates to national security. But for Parliament, we are used to having a particular person that we know is in charge of a sector. So, it is common practice for a President to say he is assigning a particular person to be responsible for National Security so that when obligations arise under this legislation, that person is answerable. But it does not stop a President from appointing a Minister for national security. We do not want it to be obligatory that he must appoint a Minister for National Security. That also creates a problem. Because even the Minister for Finance—most provisions of the Constitution do not even mention specific Ministers. They are created by Executive Instruments. Apart from the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, this is the first time since the provision on the Attorney-General that Ministers are actually mentioned for sectors.

So let us not bind a President to appoint a Minister for National Security.

5:16 p.m.

**Mr Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana:**  
Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I want to take it from where the Leader of Government Business ended. In view of the provisions of Article 78, I am not

sure whether Clause 11 can in any way overreach the power of the President to appoint a Minister and that Minister can be assigned any responsibility.

As a matter of fact, currently, we have an example that the Minister for Finance can capably handle the portfolio of the Minister for Defence as we are seeing right now. So, it appears that that is also very possible.

But Mr Speaker, there should also be an opportunity for a President—I think this provision makes room for it—to decide to have a coordinating Minister for National Security. So that whatever the Ministry for Defence is doing, they do it in silos—the Ministry of the Interior, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and so on and so forth, would want to have one coordinating Minister to deal with it. This provision does not take away the power of the President to assign, then in future, any President can decide to appoint a Minister for National Security, then I think we can let this go.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, one of the major deliberations that made the Committee arrive at this rendition is considering by practice how the implementation of Act 526 has been, which tilted towards assigned ministerial responsibility, and then the dichotomy of Act 1030, which expressly gives the power to the President to appoint and create a whole bureaucracy. We said that Presidents in the past have belonged to either of these two schools of thought. We do not want a

legislation that will have to be amended in case another President comes and has a different policy direction that is tilting towards Act 1030 or tilting towards Act 526. So, for it to be a longstanding legislation, we allow this rendition.

So, if a President comes, for instance, who feels that he wants to invoke an Executive Instrument to be able to create the office or the Ministry of National Security, by the flexibility of this rendition, the President may so proceed, and this same provision also—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Show me a single Ministry apart from the Ministry of National Security that is created by an Act of Parliament. Do we create a Ministry by an Act of Parliament?

**Rev Fordjour:** So, Mr Speaker, for an Act of Parliament, it is only Act 1030 that I have observed.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, so, generally, Ministries are created by Executive Instrument. So, you need no provision in this law to be able to create the Ministry. Ministries are not created by an Act of Parliament. So, it was an oversight, in fact, an error in Act 1030 that Act 1030 creates a Ministry for National Security.

**Rev Fordjour:** In defence of this current rendition, that it serves a dual purpose and gives the flexibility for Presidents—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What is the dual purpose?

**Rev Fordjour:** The dual purpose for a President who believes in Act 526, for instance, and then at the same time, a President who may believe in a school of thought—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Or a President who wants to create a Ministry for National Security. Let the President do that by Executive Instrument, which is an appropriate instrument by which one can create a Ministry.

**Rev Fordjour:** So, Mr Speaker, we are speaking the same language. We are singing from the same hymn book, and our principles are the same. So, we agree on that. In support that we leave the rendition the way it is.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes. Very much so, but Dr Bryan Acheampong said he wonders if I am seeing it. I saw it, and I read it. I was at the Committee level and he was missing.

So, I will put the Question on the entire clause 11—

Hon Members, there is no further proposed amendment to clause 11 on the Floor. So, what are we doing to ourselves?

Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, just to draw your attention, we have been conferring and communicating. They have drawn my attention to the use of the word “shall”. “Shall” means that the President must necessarily assign responsibility to a Minister, but it should

be a more permissive provision to say that “the President may...”

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, are you looking at clause 11(2)? If the President is permitted and he decides not to do it, who performs the function as stated in clause 11(2)? That is why they use the word “shall”. So, the President must, of necessity, assign.

**Mr Ayariga:** All right.

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, precisely the guidance you have given, that was a principle on which the Committee agreed on “shall” because the two functions indicated are very crucial. One, for the parliamentary oversight of the intelligence sector. So, if we leave it at the prerogative of the President, that is, “may” and the President opts not to appoint, there shall be a vacuum to the extent that we would not have a Minister whose obligation would be to appear before Parliament to submit the reviewed coordinated national security strategy and also to be able to submit reports. We want to be sure that the exercise of oversight function is not left in ambiguity.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, if you look at Article 183, the President is the Chairperson of the Security Council, but you cannot bring the President to Parliament to come and answer questions. So, if there is a question directed to that particular sector, there must be an

assigned Minister who will come and answer the question. Now, it says:

“The Minister assigned responsibility under Section 1 shall submit a coordinated national Security Policy and Strategy within two years after the inauguration of a new Parliament”.

The President himself cannot come and perform this function; therefore, by necessity, the President must assign this function to a Minister.

“(b) in respect of each year, submit a report to Parliament on the security and intelligence agencies.

(c) perform any other function as the Council may...”

So, there must always be a Minister assigned, and that is why they use the word “shall”.

Hon Majority Leader, you got it.  
Yes, Hon Bryan Acheampong?

5:26 p.m.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, we have to find a way to decouple the ministerial responsibility, which is the total coordinated Minister to the functions of reporting to Parliament. The Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts can submit a coordinated national security policy strategy on behalf of the President to Parliament. Here, we are talking about ministerial responsibility, which goes beyond just reporting to Parliament.

And such ministerial responsibility, we are saying the one to the Minister for National Security—Mr Speaker, even at the Committee—I participated in some of the Committee meetings—it was not to suggest only for the reporting to Parliament; we are talking about ministerial responsibility. If it takes us to decouple clause 11(1) from the functions as we said in clause 11(2), then, Mr Speaker, the Parliament must find a way to do so.

*Question put and amendment agreed to*

Clause 11 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Hon Member, before Clause 12, the Chairperson has to move the amendment in xxi.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move, xxi. Sectional note after Clause 11- amendment proposed.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Sectional note as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 12 — Composition of security and intelligence agencies

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, there seem to be a slight problem because in our original proposals, we have some proposed amendments, but the *Order Paper* does not seem to reflect same.



**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** If you have the proposed amendment but it is not captured on the *Order Paper*, please do so.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, the proposal was to *delete* “security” and simply maintain “intelligence agencies” in the Act comprising Office of National Security Coordinator.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What will the rendition be?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** The rendition would be “the intelligence agencies in this Act comprise the...”

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Then why is the whole Act “securities and intelligence agencies”?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, the original proposal was to remove “security” from that head note as well. It was to read, “Composition of intelligence agencies.”

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Do you have a composition of security agencies?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, the Committee was of the view that the reference here was to the intelligence agencies and the security agencies referred to was the Ghana Police Service, the Ghana Armed Forces, the Ghana Prisons Service and other sister agencies. So, the Committee was of the view that removing “security”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** All right. So, we have finished with the “security”, and we are now on “intelligence”. The proposal is to delete— So is that the amendment to proffer to the head notes?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Yes, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** This is consequential to the head notes.

**Mr Agbodza:** Mr Speaker, the entire Bill is about Security and Intelligence Agencies. If we read the Memorandum, it talks clearly about it. Deleting these two basically means that it is a different view.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, but look at it from Clause 6.

First, the Hon Member can look at it from Clause 2. It talks about Security Council. This aspect is talking about the intelligence aspect.

Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I was just about to say what you said, which is that there are two broad issues dealt with: security and intelligence. Earlier clauses focused on security-related institutions. Even though intelligence agencies perform security functions, they are a distinct category of setups. So these clauses can actually be focused on the intelligence agencies. What I have a problem with is how the Office of the Coordinator will be a part of the

intelligence agencies. But when we get there, we will hear what the Committee has in store for us.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** So, the proposed amendment to the headline is to delete “security and”, so that the rendition will be “Composition of intelligence agencies.”

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, that is correct.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Draftspersons, take note.

Yes?

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, rightly so. I support that it is restricted to the composition of intelligence agencies. This Clause is just defining which agencies are categorised or classified as intelligence agencies. On that note, I propose an amendment in (a), that Clause 12, paragraph (a), *delete*.

The reason I am proposing that we delete Clause (a), which says that the intelligence—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I think the proposed amendment by the Chairperson of the Committee to *delete* the headnote after Clause 11 was wrong. What we should be deleting from the headnote is “security and”. But the proposed amendment here is that “Sectional Note after Clause 11, *delete*”. So, this proposed amendment is wrong.

So, I will come back to that. Let us do the needful.

So, do the proposal and *delete* “security and”.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, for the sectional note, *delete* “security and”. The new rendition would be “intelligence agencies”.

**Dr A. K. T. Mahama:** Mr Speaker, that was what I was trying to draw attention to, but we already carried that particular amendment which you put to a vote. I do not know whether we have to come back to it.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The earlier decision is hereby rescinded. I will put a question on the amendment proposed by the Chairperson to *delete* “security and”

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Sectional note after Clause 11 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** There are consequential amendments. I direct the draftspersons, flowing from the proposed amendment to the sectional note, do the consequential amendments.

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, I beg to move: proposed amendment to Clause 12 paragraph (a), *delete*—

What I am seeking to do is that “office of”, if I am to take together with the entire Clause 12, it will read, “the intelligence agencies in this act comprise (a) Office of the National Security Coordinator.”

I am proposing that we delete the “Office of the National Security Coordinator”. This is because the National Security Coordinator is a coordinator. He is the incumbent that is expected to coordinate all these intelligence agencies. As a matter of fact, flowing from decisions of the National Security Council in Clause 1, the Coordinator is the one who is supposed to coordinate all these decisions that have come from National Security Council and also expected to coordinate all the intelligence agencies, that is BNI, NSB and the external intelligence.

And so we cannot subsume the Coordinator and create their office as an agency. When we do that, we are undermining the coordinating role that the Coordinator has to play. By practice, the National Security Coordinator, even beyond the intelligence agencies, is expected to coordinate activities of other security agencies. It would be wrong for us to create the Office of the National Security Coordinator as an agency. Once we reduce the Office of the National Security Coordinator to a level of an agency, we now undermine their powers or functions to be able to coordinate activities or decisions emanating from the National Security Council.

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** Mr Speaker, the Committee agreed on the fact that the Office of the Coordinator is not an agency. So rightfully so, it must be deleted from here. I am not sure why it did not feature in the *Order Paper*. The Committee actually did agree that the Office of the National Security Coordinator—

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Respectfully, Mr Speaker, the Minister is here and he always comes by to say they prepared this and they have a reason why we put it in there. We want to hear from the Minister.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** It does not lie in your mouth to say you want to hear from the Minister. You are not presiding.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** I take it back, Mr Speaker.

5:36 p.m.

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** I think we should look at the substance and not the form. Mr Speaker, I want to agree partly with my Colleague, Hon Ntim Fordjour, so that instead of Office of National Security Coordinator, we would rather have National Security Secretariat.

Mr Speaker, the issue is that, that body, National Security Secretariat perform security and intelligence functions.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Let me put the question. You can propose your amendment after.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, my proposed amendment is to continue to have (a) there but differently worded.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Then it is now otiose because the entire clause is deleted in its entirety, so there is nothing

to be amended. But if you have a fresh amendment, you can do so.

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, I am proposing an amendment to Clause 12 (a), or if you would like, an insertion since it has been deleted.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** There is no Clause 12 (a) to be amended.

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** An insertion of a new Clause 12 (a) to read “National Security Secretariat” because for all intents and purposes, that office performs intelligence functions, just like BNI and External Security as well. Mr Speaker —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The Majority Leader explained to you a few minutes ago that we have security and we have intelligence. We have finished with the securities and are now dealing with intelligence.

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** Rightly so, Mr Speaker. That is exactly what the National Security Secretariat does; they do not do security, they do intelligence. I think that it will be remiss on our part if we take it out completely.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Then propose an amendment and let me put the question and see whether Hon Ntim Fordjour will not oppose you. What is your proposed amendment?

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** The rendition should be:

“The intelligence agencies in this Act comprise the:

(a) National Security Secretariat

(b) Intelligence agency existing immediately.”

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The amendment is for the consideration of the House.

**Mr Ayariga:** Just for my education, where else in the Bill have we established a National Security Secretariat? He should show me. We have to create the secretariat before we can now identify it as an intelligence agency. Is there a provision creating a secretariat?

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, as you would recall, Mr Speaker himself painstakingly was part of the winnowing process and you would bear me out that there are many considerations and amendment considered extensively at the winnowing stage, many of which are not advertised but as and when we get there, we move.

So, to address the concern of my respected Hon Colleague, Mr Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana, there is supposed to be an amendment proposed for the creation of the Office of the National Security Coordinator to establish it, but not as an intelligence agency.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What the Majority Leader is saying is that the secretariat you are talking about must be established in the Bill for it to be part of

the composition, but it is not an establishment in the Bill. Why are you asking that it should be part of the composition of the intelligence agencies? So, it is like putting something on nothing. It will not stand.

Constitutionally, we do not have a position of a secretariat. The secretary to Cabinet is a secretary to the council. So which secretariat are you talking about?

**Mr A. T. Sulemana:** Mr Speaker, by the same parity of reasoning, I do not know where else we have created internal intelligence agency or external intelligence agency. Mr Speaker, I stand corrected, it does not really matter but it is worth bringing to the attention of this House so that at any point in time, if we are doing the wrong thing, we can correct ourselves. It should not be the case that because we have gotten so far, we cannot go back. We have to get this done and done right. Mr Speaker, it is for the consideration of the house.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** If you look at the Intelligence Agencies Act, it is a creature in that Act. But the office that you are talking about, which law establishes it? Because it must first of all be in existence.

**Alhaji Muntaka:** I just want to allay the fear of my Colleague, Hon Tampuli concerning where the national security activity will be situated. Just as when we finish this, the next thing that needs to be done is the national security coordinator's activities. So, he should

just be patient. When we get there, we can get the right renditions to take care of the concerns that he is talking about. But surely in the Bill, there is a provision for the appointment of deputies and what they do. But that will be after we have created the intelligence group. So, if we could just be patient, when we get there, we will have the opportunity to make all the necessary amendments.

**Dr A. K. T. Mahama:** Mr Speaker, I am proposing a further amendment to Clause 12 by a *deletion* in (b), “internal intelligence agency existing immediately before the coming into force of this Act and known as the National Intelligence Bureau, now referred to as the...”. The new rendition will read, “Bureau of National Intelligence”.

Mr Speaker, I make this proposal cognisant of the fact that Clause 7 makes provision for the Bureau of National Intelligence and it did not come with this verbose and rather superfluous wording that is associated with Clause 12 (b) in my opinion. So, my proposed amendment is to make it read succinctly and simply as “Bureau of National Intelligence”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, the proposal is to *delete* (b) and instead *insert* Bureau of National Intelligence.

*Question put and amendment negated.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I will now put a question on the entire Clause 12.

5:46 p.m.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, Clause 12 (c). I think it is an oversight. In this country, we only have a Research Department. I am not too sure why we are classifying the Research Department as an external security agency in this House. *[Interruption]* But be careful, Mr Minister. It is a Research Department. Let it remain a Research Department.

It is not up to us—for national security reasons, to now classify, so anybody, if you show up as a research staff member of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, now the whole world knows you as an intelligence officer, is that what — we do not have to accept it. So, if we have a Research Department, I do not know why the whole Ghana Parliament is making known that our Research Department is an Intelligence Agency. I think we should find a way to be careful with some of these things. It is a Research Department of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and it should remain a Research Department.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** You are talking about (c)?

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** We cannot come here and be admitting things that —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, but the (c) says: “External intelligence agency existing immediately before the coming into force of this Act and known as the Research Department.”

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Yes, Mr Speaker, nobody has in any law mentioned to us that the Research Department is an external intelligence agency. We know them as the Research Department of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, helping the Ministry, collecting information and sharing with the Ministry of Tourism, Arts and Culture, the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry and the like. I do not think that we should come to Parliament and label the Research Department as an external—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Have you looked at Clause 12 of Act 1030? Do you have it before you? Other than that, I can read it for you.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, I led the passage of Act 1030.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, so can I read it for you? It states:

“The Departments existing immediately before the coming into force of this Act and known as the Bureau of National Investigation now referred to as the National Intelligence Bureau and the Research Department respectively are continued in existence under this Act as the Internal and External Intelligence Agencies of the State.”

That is where the internal and external agencies of the states are used in Act 1030.

**Dr Bryan Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, this has created a lot of problems for us.

If we have an opportunity to make an amendment, then the platform should be used to correct it. Mr Speaker, the Research Department—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** In line with section 12 of Act 1030, they are also using the word “external” here because Act 1030 makes reference to internal and external intelligence agencies. So, this amendment was occasioned by what was in the earlier law.

**Alhaji Muntaka:** Mr Speaker, I wanted to draw your attention to simply refer him to clause 10 of Act 526 and like you rightly mentioned, clause 12 of Act 1030. It is the mentioning and the debate that rather exposes us. In fact, nobody in this world working within the security services does not know what we are talking about, except that we should not be echoing it. It is in our 1992 Constitution; it is in Act 526 and it is in Act 1030. It cannot be different from what we are saying. So, Mr Speaker, let me put the question.

*Question put and amendment agreed to.*

Clause 12 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, let me thank Colleagues. I think we can draw the curtains here and then commence the debate on the Message on the State of the Nation.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we have come to a temporary end of the Consideration Stage for today — Yes, Hon Fordjour?

**Rev Fordjour:** I have no opposition to the proposal made by the Hon Majority Leader, except to draw the attention of Mr Speaker to the fact that the amendment just taken in Clause 12, which now deletes the Office of the National Security Coordinator from being an intelligence agency and now, that has come to be at variance with paragraph 5 of the Memorandum accompanying the Bill. It will be proper for the Minister to take the clarity. I read paragraph 5 of the Memorandum:

“The Bill establishes the Office of the National Security Coordinator to be part of the security and intelligence agencies...”—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, you are completely out of order. When a Bill is introduced, it is a document of this House. The Memorandum enables you to debate at Second Reading. Once you are at the Consideration Stage, you are free to propose amendments and if the amendment is carried by the House, that is the rendition of the House. The House will pass the law as it deems fit. You cannot say an amendment is inconsistent with the Memorandum. No. That is why the Bill is entirely in your domain.

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, I am guided. But the fact that it is a cardinal principle, then we will end up having a Bill whose cardinal principle is

completely different from the products that have been passed—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why in *Pepper v Hart*, parliamentary debates is an aid to interpretation. It did not say Memorandum should be an aid to interpretation but the debate—what resulted in Parliament agreeing on that particular rendition will aid when it comes to the interpretation of the Bill. At the Consideration Stage, we do not behave as if we are at Second Reading.

5:56 p.m.

**Rev Fordjour:** Mr Speaker, I do not intend to take us back to Second Reading, but this is an important signal. As you are aware and you bear us out, at Winnowing, one of the major contentions—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That is why Second Reading is allowed. More so, when we bring the Consideration Stage to an end, we do not talk about the Bill again. So, Hon Member, kindly resume your seat?

Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, we can take the item numbered 10. It is a Motion.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, the item numbered 10, Motion.

I will call on the Hon Member for Bolgatanga Central, Mr Isaac Adongo.

You are speaking for 10 minutes, beginning from now.

## MOTION

### Message on the State of the Nation, 2026

**Mr Isaac Adongo (NDC — Bolgatanga Central):** Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House thanks H. E. the President of the Republic for the Message on the State of the Nation which he delivered to Parliament on Friday, 27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026.

In so doing, I would like to contribute to the debate to thank His Excellency the President. Mr Speaker, His Excellency the President delivered a Message on the State of the Nation that marked a complete departure from those of several years past to which we have listened. Over the years, we have been accustomed to Messages on the State of the Nation that gave Ghanaians heartbreak, that made the people of Ghana suddenly lose hope in our democracy. But on Friday, His Excellency the President gave a lot of hope. The Message on the State of the Nation that he delivered indicated that the country had made significant progress, progress from the despair that we faced, from the collapse of the economy that he inherited, and for the renewal of various sectors of the economy that were in shambles.

Mr Speaker, His Excellency the President spoke extensively on the



economy, which became a major point of despair for the people of Ghana. His Excellency the President indicated that within one year, he had been able to stabilise the economy and the fundamentals of the economy had returned to the levels that we had never seen in decades.

Mr Speaker, for the first time in decades, particularly within the Fourth Republic, inflation is trending at 3.8 per cent as at the end of last month. Gross Domestic Product (GDP) for the first three quarters of the year recorded in excess of 6 per cent, and the country also recorded a positive primary balance that had deluded this country for so many years. The result is that the country now had a hold on the economy and can therefore have the comfort to move towards the development agenda that we so much desired. As a result, His Excellency President could not have put it aptly when he said that the country is on the runway and advised everybody to fasten our seatbelts.

But Mr Speaker, there have been several comments that have occasioned this Message on the State of the Nation and I would like to take time to address some of them. We have since forgottenthat for three or four years consecutively in our country, the IMF and the World Bank, leading to the year, 2022 when we declared bankruptcy, that our country was facing very high risk of debt default. Unfortunately, the managers of the economy at the time did not heed to that. The result was that the risk of debt default finally became actual default in December 2022 when the

country declared to the world that we could not pay our debt and file for bankruptcy with our creditors.

But Mr Speaker, even in the midst of us not paying our debt, we still could not manage the foreign exchange. The cedi was trading at about GH¢17.00 to a dollar, but today it is possible to buy a dollar at about GH¢11 and His Excellency said that he did not have to arrest the dollar. What he did was to strengthen the cedi so that it could put up a good fight against the other major foreign currencies. Mr Speaker, simply put, when one's child is bullied in school, one does not arrive in the school with policemen to arrest the children that bully the child. One trains the child to take up his own and fight to save his life, and that is exactly what His Excellency the President did with the cedi.

But Mr Speaker, our Colleagues have tended to tell us that the Gold Board that we set up to support the cedi is nothing new and somehow, somebody who was the head of the economic management team that failed our country is the one who brought about the purchase of gold at the Bank of Ghana. Mr Speaker, I want to put it on record that in 1958, when some people's fathers and mothers had not even met, when we introduced our own traditional currency, the assets that backed that currency included gold.

Mr Speaker, in 1961/1962, the managers of the economy took a very bold decision to ramp up the purchase of gold to support our reserves at the Bank of Ghana. They increased gold holdings at the Bank of Ghana to about 8.7 metric

tonnes, which was valued at the time at US\$3.7 million. Mr Speaker, it would interest you to note that those gold that we refer to as the legacy gold, was Dr Mahamudu Bawumia and his people who sold all that gold for US\$100 million in 2022, just to balance the books at the Bank of Ghana.

So, Mr Speaker, rather than say that somebody brought about the purchase of gold at the Bank of Ghana, the truth is that our gold that had stood in our books since 1961 was rather sold in 2022 by that person. The truth is that Dr Mahamudu Bawumia did not bring any original idea for the purchase of gold at the Bank of Ghana. As a matter of fact, gold was purchased at the Bank of Ghana as far back as 1958. And the legacy gold that was bought in 1961 was sold by Dr Mahamudu Bawumia in 2022. So clearly, all these settings, all these pretence and high sounding to try and give somebody credit, is neither here nor there. The facts speak for themselves that the buying of gold at the Bank of Ghana started several decades before His Excellency President was even born and became a Vice President.

Mr Speaker, I have also heard some people who misunderstood the statement that His Excellency the President made, and Mr Speaker, with your permission I would like to quote, he said:

“Mr Speaker, to reduce Ghana’s 300 to 400 million per annum import bill on poultry, the Government of Ghana has set up a programme to reverse this trend”.

But Mr Speaker, His Excellency said that part of that arrangement also includes the production of poultry by households in addition to those that are being produced by commercial farmers. Mr Speaker, he says that:

“The Nkoko Nketenkete Programme is underway and the target is to reach 600,000 households. Even before the launch of the programme, 720,000 birds...”

And for those of you who are wishing for a slip, please pay attention. This is what is in the meat and this is what is captured by the *Hansard* and this is the truth, that it was 720,000 birds that were shared among 13,000 Ghanaians. So, for those who are out there making noise, this is the truth and nothing but the truth.

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that our Colleagues are not interested in the debate because the cocoa politics has died. The cocoa *jandam* is gone. Today, everybody knows that Ghana pays twice as much as La Côte d’Ivoire for the price of cocoa. So, for those who are out there deceiving some farmers, that somehow it was John Dramani Mahama that was reducing cocoa and was pointing to La Côte d’Ivoire as the saviour of the cocoa industry, today, we want them to visit the farmers and tell them that cocoa is more expensive in Ghana than it is in La Côte d’Ivoire, and that they rather may see people in La Côte d’Ivoire smuggling cocoa to sell at a higher price in Ghana. So of course, after having seen the collapse of the cocoa politics, it is not surprising that their seats are empty because they have nothing to say again.

Mr Speaker, another most important issue that our people have tended to do is to tell the people of Ghana that all the good news is settings. I do not know what they mean by settings, but of course, I want to tell them that Ghanaians know settings when they see one. Settings is when somebody loses a general election, a general election for which his party elected him as a flag bearer.

6:06 p.m.

The person now comes to a general election and is woefully disappointed and rejected by the people of Ghana. He goes back to the people for a flagbearer election that he did not lose before, wins that election, and says that the stone that the builders rejected shall be the head of the cornerstone. Has he won the general election? Was he rejected as a flagbearer? So where is the stone coming from? He should wait until he wins a general election and then he can say that the stone that the builders rejected has become the head of the cornerstone. It is not that he goes to win the same election that he has won before and then come and say, it is possible for people to now see that these are what people who are doing the “settings”. The “settings” is to misinterpret the Bible to suit their needs and leave the reality. The reality is that even what he got in the last flagbearer election—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up. It is now the turn of Hon Rev Ntim Fordjour. You are speaking for 15 minutes.

**Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin South):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise to contribute to the Motion and to indicate that I speak not just as a Member of Parliament or Ranking Member of the Committee on Defence and Interior of Parliament, but I speak as a son of a cocoa farmer. I speak as someone born into a family of cocoa farming, someone coming from a beautiful village, Assin Kruwa, with the entire constituency engaged in cocoa farming. I speak as one of the affected members of over 4 million cocoa farmers that this Government deceived and promised an amount not less than GHC6,000, and in some instances even GHC6,500, only to obtain their votes and to turn around to reduce the meagre prices they had offered them by GHC1,000. I speak as one of the many cocoa farmers who have been rendered poorer—*[Interruption]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Fordjour, sorry let me correct this. You are speaking for ten minutes.

**Rev Fordjour:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I speak as one of the 4 million cocoa farmers and their dependents who have been rendered poorer and deceived, and today they are making reference to Ivory Coast. No Minister of the Ivory Coast went around seeking votes of cocoa farmers, promising them GHC6,500 per bag. They did and turned around to cheat and shortchange them, and to steal GHC1,000 from one bag of cocoa.

Mr Speaker, we are talking about a State where traders no longer feel safe. Even to embark upon their cross-border

trading that some few years ago they could boldly go about to ensure that tomatoes were brought in. Today, due to the failure of the Government in ensuring that intelligence is effective and ensuring that we put in adequate measures for the protection of our citizens within our borders and beyond our borders, our tomato traders, eight of them, sadly met their untimely horrific killing in a terrorist attack in Burkina Faso. May their souls rest in peace.

Today, we are talking about fisherfolks who a few years ago could go about fishing but today do not feel safe again because of piracy, which has become the order of the day. At one time, an incident reported in Tema, another reported in Volta, and recently, just last week, a pirate incident reported in Senya Breku on our own territorial waters. Our fisherfolks no longer feel safe because of a systemic leadership failure in the defence sector by the failure of the President in appointing a substantive Minister for Defence for seven months now. No serious country would go without a Minister for Defence substantive for seven months amid all the threats in our geopolitics, amid the threats of extremism and violent extremism and terrorism. We cannot continue to have these calls fall on deaf ears.

Mr Speaker, my Hon Colleague is attempting to rehash the false reality that was captured in the lamentation of the State of the Nation. But what appears to be nice numbers on paper is actually reflecting in rising cost of living in the pockets of our people. Today, they boast about inflation and the exchange

rate going down but if our citizens are feeling palpable hardship, then what is the essence of what appears to be declining? How real is it?

Mr Speaker, what shall it profit this Government if they brag about artificial economic improvement when they are not even able to pay cocoa farmers what is due them for four good months? What shall it profit this Government if they fail to pay cocoa farmers four good months of their sweat and hard work if indeed their economic narrative is one that is stellar? What shall it profit a country to have exchange rate and inflation that appear to be low, and still even fail to pay the pensions of our soldiers until the retired soldiers went to court up in arms before the Government was compelled to pay their pensions and gratuities?

This Government, in all that they are trying to tout, failed to pay the non-salary allowances of our prison officers for one good year. The rent allowances for the entire 2025 of our hard-working prison officers were in arrears. They could not even pay rent allowances for our prison officers yet they want us to clap for them on economic prowess.

Mr Speaker, in 2021, this country could boast proudly as a country recognised by the Global Peace Index as the second most peaceful country in Africa. In 2021, this country could boast as the country recognised by the Global Peace Index as the 38<sup>th</sup> most peaceful country in the world.

But today, due to faulty security sector policies, inactions and negligence on the part of the Commander-in-Chief of the

Republic, our security has deteriorated and according to the Global Peace Index 2025, we have fallen from the second most peaceful in Africa to seventh. And sadly, around the world, we have declined from being the 38<sup>th</sup> most peaceful country in the world to now 61<sup>st</sup>. That is how deteriorating our security situation is.

Mr Speaker, all these are because of unpopular decisions. All these are because of the failure of the President to appreciate the cry of the citizens whose aspiration is to feel safe within their territorial borders. And they know, fundamentally from Article 83 of the Constitution, that the Minister for Defence is a key member of the national security architecture of this country. So, the negligence of the Government from appointing a Minister for Defence is one that is reckless, Mr Speaker, to put it mildly.

It does not end here. Certain key investments that ought to be put into the security sector are also reneged on. Our fisherfolks just want to feel safe on our waters. They are asking that this Government must not pay lip service to what appeared in the 2025 Message on the State of the Nation by President Mahama, which was copied and pasted and found expression also in the 2026 Message on the State of the Nation by the President, where he says “steps are being taken for the acquisition of two offshore patrol vessels”. He said it last year and has repeated it this year.

Mr Speaker, to date, not even a single agreement is before this House to give

credence to that rhetoric. So, all that our fisherfolks are asking is that they should get off their guilt of the past.

A few years ago in 2024, publicly in this Chamber, this side of the Majority, when they were in Minority, opposed the acquisition of offshore patrol vessel. So today, because of the guilt, they are not bold to bring it. Our Side are going to be nationalistic. When they bring it, we shall support them to acquire two offshore patrol vessels; station one on the Togo border and one on the Ivory Coast border. They are combat vessels that will ensure that pirates would no longer find our territorial waters safe for their dwelling.

6:16 p.m.

Mr Speaker, all that we are saying, our soldiers no longer feel safe. We see videos of soldiers who are mandated to protect our environment from *galamsey* running for their lives because some party foot soldiers have received an emboldened order to chase them away. That is the state of the nation as we speak today, when even security officers no longer feel safe.

We are talking about a state of our country where over 48,000 of our compatriots from the Sawla-Tuna-Kalba, Bole Bamboi and Gbenyiri conflict were displaced, and not a single shelter was even constructed for them. 13,000 fled as refugees to the Ivory Coast, 10,000 fled as refugees to Burkina Faso, and even a response to this claim is in this *Order Paper*, which the Minister for the Interior was scheduled to answer.

Mr Speaker, we are asking them to account for our own compatriots who are citizens of Ghana who were displaced as a result of their negligence in ensuring security. But they are quick to fly soldiers with resources to Jamaica for rebuilding when they have neglected their own Sawla-Tuna-Kalba and Gbenyiri. Outside the gentility, home cry.

Mr Speaker, the State is unsafe, but all we want is the President, the Commander-in-Chief of the Ghana Armed Forces, to pay attention to the security sector and to the welfare of the men and women in uniform, who are proudly preserving the security of this country and to fulfil the promise to the cocoa farmer by paying what they deserve. They have lost a lot of livelihoods, and they are selling their lands for *galamsey*. This is a covert way of this Government—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up.

It is now the turn of Hon Felix Kwakye Ofosu. You are speaking for 10 minutes.

**Minister for Government Communications (Mr Felix Kwakye Ofosu):** Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, let me begin by commending His Excellency, President John Dramani Mahama, highly, for presenting a message of hope on the state of the nation. The President

demonstrated that indeed he is up to the task and that the men and women whom he has selected to help him manage the affairs of the country are up to the task, and the results have been telling.

Mr Speaker, prior to becoming President, even the unborn knew that the biggest problem of this country was our economy, which had been pulverised and destroyed by the government that we succeeded. Through hard work, grit and consistency, today, like Lazarus, the Ghanaian economy has woken from the dead. Like the phoenix, the Ghanaian economy has risen from the ashes of collapse. And this has happened because of prudent economic management. Without touting their credentials to the highest heavens, the men and women in charge of running this economy, the likes of the Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, the Governor of the Bank of Ghana, and all the hardworking people who contribute to the running of this economy, have demonstrated the capacity to deliver.

Mr Speaker, the Ghanaian economy was bedevilled by three enemies. The first was unsustainable debt, which, as the President rightly put it, shackled us and made us sink to the depths of the ocean. Today, our debt is far more manageable than before. GH¢82.00 billion of our debt have been chopped off through the prudent management of this Government.

Mr Speaker, the second enemy of the Ghanaian economy was inflation. Inflation ate the disposable income of the people of Ghana. It made it difficult for

the people of Ghana to retain the value of the money they had. Whatever little was left in their pockets was dissipated on rising prices, which, daily, went beyond their means. Their purchasing power was seriously depleted.

Through hard work, effective strategy, and prudent measures, today inflation is under control and is at a measly 3.8 per cent from the highs of 23 per cent. At some point, it was even at 54 per cent. Today, inflation has reduced. It has not reduced on paper, as claimed by my good Friend on the other Side. Every honest assessment of the situation will show that the prices of thousands of goods and items on the markets have reduced.

Mr Speaker, basic items that we purchase, like rice, margarine, *gari*, *kokonte*, oats, oil, yams, palm fruits, meat, chicken, key soap, dettol, and all the thousands of items that we can list have reduced in prices. This is because inflation has been brought under control. The rate at which inflation used to rise is much lower now. At 3.8 per cent, it meant, Mr Speaker, that compared to the same period in January 2024, the rate at which prices of goods and services are rising is 3.8 per cent. This is far better news for the Ghanaian than they have ever had under the entire duration of the reign of the New Patriotic Party (NPP).

Mr Speaker, the third enemy of the Ghanaian economy was rapid exchange rate depreciation. The previous government met the exchange rates at GH¢4.00 to a dollar. By the time they left it, it hovered around GH¢16.00 on the forest markets. This meant that imported items kept on rising. The

exchange rates became the handmaiden of inflation because that was essentially what was fuelling inflation. Through consistent efforts and ingenious policies, today the exchange rate is under control. The Ghana cedi recorded its steepest climb against the U.S. dollar. It made a gain of 40.7 per cent, which has not been recorded in living Ghanaian memory.

Mr Speaker, this did not happen by chance. It was through the GoldBod arrangement, which ensures that we are able to export significant quantities of gold and bring foreign exchange into this country, which is then made available to those who need it. And for that reason, our currency has remained stable. The impact of this is that Ghanaians breathe much easier now than they did under the NPP. Their cost of living is lower now than it was under the NPP. Any claim by our Colleagues on the other Side that things are more difficult today than they were previously simply cannot be sustained on the basis of facts.

Mr Speaker, the Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism of this House has a report in which they acknowledge the reduction in prices of thousands of items on the market.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by correcting some distortions that have arisen in the wake of the President's delivery. We note that our Colleagues go about saying that the President has said that we distributed 720 birds to about 13,500 people. That could only have been a slip of the tongue, because the script, as is available, shows that it was 720,000 birds that the President meant.

Indeed, long before the President came to this House, the Minister of Food and Agriculture had appeared on the government accountability series, which I hosted, and he had put this figure out. So, it is a matter of public record, and it has never been up for debate.

Mr Speaker, no serious analyst analysing the state of a country will waste even a second on a slip of tongue. It has also been claimed that the President said that the Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) has recovered GH¢600 million from Operation Recover All Loot (ORAL). That is not accurate. The President never made reference to ORAL in respect of the GH¢600 million. EOCO has existed long before the coming into force of ORAL. They do routine investigations of economic crimes. In 2025, they investigated about 462 cases involving money laundering, cybercrime, and carjacking, among others. It was the proceeds of those that the President reported as GH¢600 million.

Mr Speaker, in respect of ORAL, unless and until persons who are under investigation or before the court have been convicted, we cannot recover anything from them. The most that can be done is that their assets can be frozen. And as far as that goes, I can report that GH¢1.5 billion in assets have been frozen by people undergoing investigations and those before the court. They include those who are involved in the 280 ORAL cases that are currently being looked into. So let the records be set straight and let people refrain from

deliberately distorting the facts that the President put out this day.

6:26 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I must also indicate that, whereas it is regrettable that some of our citizens have had to suffer death when doing business across our borders, it is not proper to attribute same to the Government of Ghana. The Government of Ghana does not control the territory of Burkina Faso and therefore, it is simply unable to bear responsibility for what happens in another country. If it were the case that these killings happened in Ghanaian territory, then the Government of Ghana could be faulted. But how can we possibly take responsibility for what has happened in another sovereign country? I think that we need to be fair to the facts, we need to be accurate and refrain from mischievous commentary when we know what the truth is.

Mr Speaker, in respect of our brothers who were attacked on the high seas in Ghana, the Ghanaian government acted with alacrity. All the 71 or so people who were involved in that fracas were rescued and brought to safety; that is a mark of a government that is responsible, responsive and an Armed Forces that is up to the task. Again, I urge my Colleagues on the other Side to refrain from this sort of mischief. It does not help our course. Indeed, had they, in those eight years, been able to procure fit-for-purpose equipment, we would not have had the situation where our Armed Forces did not have the requisite equipment to respond effectively to



crises like that. But thank God President Mahama is in the saddle and he is making colossal investments to ensure that we procure the needed equipment.

I am happy that he has indicated his readiness to support governments to procure those items. The relevant agreements will come to this House just as the agreements to purchase helicopters and the aircraft came to this House and were passed.

So, my Brother can look forward to similar agreements to help retool. President Mahama will undertake the single largest retooling of Ghana's Armed Forces in history and therefore, he is prepared to protect the country, defend our territorial integrity, whether by air, by sea, or by land and he will keep the people of Ghana safe. That is a solemn promise he has made to all of us.

Mr Speaker, finally, on Operation Recover All Loot (ORAL), the President said that indeed he is committed to ensuring that everybody who has squandered Ghanaian funds legally accounts for same and that is what—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, your time is up. I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Onyina-Acheampong. You are speaking for five minutes.

**Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East):** Thank you Mr Speaker for giving me the opportunity to contribute to this ongoing debate on the Message on the State of the Nation presented to us by His Excellency the President.

Mr Speaker, before the advent of the President to this Chamber to deliver this message, I was highly expectant. I thought that the President would come and possibly announce measures that would bring some form of relief to Ghanaians. However, this message turned out to be a lot of lamentations, self-glorification, manifesto reading exercise and most importantly, a rehash of their failed and unfulfilled promises.

Mr Speaker, this Government seems to be so fixated on the macroeconomic indicators, such as inflation and the cedi appreciation, more to the extent that it has gone completely oblivious of the untold hardships that an artificially stimulated indicator brings to bear on Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, they injected US\$10 billion of our hard-earned money just to stabilise the currency. To put this into context, this US\$10 billion is the entire budget for their flagship programme, the Big Push, for four years. But they injected this US\$10 billion just in one year, just to make them look good.

Mr Speaker, when the cedi is artificially stimulated, there is a lack of export competitiveness, because the cedi is stronger and the cost of our exports becomes very high. So, it disincentivises exporters and the people who are outside getting our exports are not ready to buy from us.

Mr Speaker, it also encourages imports, which is why cocoa farmers are

crying and maize farmers are crying, because a lot of people are importing maize. Rice farmers are crying, beans farmers are crying, tomato traders are crying and cashew farmers are crying because this Government has chosen to artificially pep up the cedi at the detriment of its own farmers.

Mr Speaker, the President told us that he has, in the past, since 2025, created 1 million jobs. This is a different statistical data from what the Ghana Statistical Service is giving us. Mr Speaker, just to assume, without admitting that this is true, because he is our President, and we know he will not willingly mislead this House, let us say 1 million jobs is true. One million divided by 276 constituencies is averagely more than 3,600 jobs per constituency.

So, I ask the Majority Side, can anybody substantiate that they have been able to provide 3,600 jobs to their constituents? If that is yes, the Minority Side have not received anything. The Statistical Service says that we have over 14 million workforce and 13 per cent of them are unemployed, leaving 1.8 million people who are unemployed. So, if in 2025, this Government has provided one million jobs, it means that out of the 1.8 million jobs, we are left with only 800,000 jobs to secure, meaning for every 10 people who were previously unemployed, five to six people have been employed.

So, I throw it to Ghanaians, the various people in the constituencies, the teeming youth who are in the constituencies, have they been

employed? **[Some Hon Members: Yes]** The President is saying he has created one million jobs. Have they been employed? **[Some Hon Members: Yes]**. The truth of the matter is that the 24-Hour Economy is not working; it is not working. Nurses have not been recruited; teachers have not been recruited.

Mr Speaker, to end, the true state of the economy is that farmers are crying. Teachers, doctors, and nurses have not been recruited. They are suffering from the rising cost of living. Unemployment, electricity bills, water bills, transport fares and imports are up. Cocoa prices, maize farmers and cashew farmers are down. There is a growing uncertainty among farmers and exporters.

Mr Speaker, Ghanaians are really feeling the negative effects of this Government. In fact, this is the true state of the nation.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, before coming to the third person on each Side, permit me to take a five-minute suspension.

6:33 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

6:35 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** It is now the turn of Hon Kofi Bente Afful. You are speaking for five minutes. You have the floor.

**Mr Kofi Bente Afful (NDC — Sefwi Wiawso):** Mr Speaker, last week Friday, the people of Ghana were privileged to have the President present

to us a written and oral submission of the state of our economy, which we are already feeling in our bodies and minds. Mr Speaker, in the expression of the state of the economy by the President, he told us that one situation that struck him so much was that at the point of taking over our nation as a result of the many “miserable” he took over was bedeviled by excessive borrowing. Ghana had borrowed so much to the extent that our debt stock stood at a percentage of 62 per cent of our Gross Domestic Product (GDP). This has resulted in the nation declaring itself bankrupt.

Mr Speaker, in fact, if the President had not taken over, this country would have been put under receivership. The country would have been liquidated to the extent that this, our august Parliament House, may have to be liquidated to realise money to pay our debts. But the President, knowing the all-round repercussions of excessive borrowing, took a strong stand to turn the corner. Today, our debt stock has been reduced by GHC82 billion. Our debt now stands at 45 per cent of GDP from an inherited position of 62 per cent. The benefits are that today; we do not need so much foreign currency to pay our debts.

So, our foreign reserves are soaring, which has made our local currency become stronger, not only to fight a handcuffed dollar, but also to fight all other trading currencies. The result also is that inflation has come down because we are no longer importing at those higher costs. Interest rates have dropped. These are all facts that I was expecting my Colleagues to allude to.

Unfortunately for them, on Friday, when they got the opportunity, they decided to establish a branch of the Winneba Youth Choir here in this Chamber. The choir master, who hails from Effutu, having a greater perspective of choral music, decided to mock Cocoa farmers by letting his choir people dress in choir robes.

In fact, what he did not know was that Cocoa farmers in Sefwi Wiawso do not dress like choristers when we are going to farm. What we do is to wear what we call our working gear, our wellington boots, and our cutlasses. I was expecting them to sing to praise, appreciate what the President has done. I was expecting them to sing *w’atua m’aka nyinaa ama me* because the President has paid the debt that he inherited from them. The debt that they accumulated; he has paid.

In fact, Mr Speaker, the President was clear that in 2025, US\$709 million of our debt were even paid ahead of schedule. Ghana, that could not pay its debt and had gone bankrupt, is now able to pay some of its debt ahead of schedule. This was clear in the international eyes to the extent that all the major rating agencies, Fitch Solutions, Standard & Poor’s, Moody, have all now improved Ghana’s credit rating. Is that true or false? They know it.

If it were them, having chalked this rating, they would be running out there going to borrow. But today, we have a President who is disciplined in his borrowing, who is so much focused that all the benefits that are accruing as a result of our debt management is

resulting in the cost of living of our people. He is thinking of—

Mr Speaker, the President has made sure that we, as Ghanaians, benefit from his debt management skills. On behalf of all of us in this Chamber, we want to appreciate the President. We know, by the next Message on the State of the Nation, we will see more for our Friends on the other Side no longer to sing choral music, but to wear white and join us to celebrate the good news that the President will bring to us. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

*[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, Hon Second Deputy Speaker will take the Chair. In doing so, I call on Hon Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni. You are speaking for five minutes. Please, you have the floor.

6:41 p.m. — [HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR ANDREW ASIAMAH AMOAKO, IN THE CHAIR]

**Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni (NPP — Nalerigu/Gambaga):** Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation presented to this House by H.E. John Dramani Mahama. Mr Speaker, I am very disappointed, and my disappointment started the very day H.E. John Dramani Mahama presented the Message on the State of the Nation to this House.

Mr Speaker, I was expecting H.E. John Dramani Mahama to use the

opportunity of the Message on the State of the Nation to apologise to the Ghanaian people for deceiving them. Mr Speaker, H.E. John Dramani Mahama in the 2024 election campaign made every single Ghanaian believe that what is shining is gold. Not knowing that the shining thing that he made Ghanaians believe and voted for him was an ordinary clay.

Mr Speaker, I want to use this opportunity to tell my Colleagues at the other Side and H.E. John Dramani Mahama, the humiliation and the frustration that he is putting our men and women in uniform is so disappointing. As a member of the Committee on Defence and Interior, for the last 13 months, Ghana Immigration Service, Ghana Fire Service and Ghana Prison Service have not received their rent allowance for the last 14 months. Mr Speaker, this is the first time in the history of this country that these security services have not received their rent allowance. But our Colleagues at the other Side want us to believe that inflation is down, interest rate is down, fuel prices are down and the dollar is down, but still, they cannot pay rent allowance to the Ghana Prison Service, Ghana Immigration Service and the Ghana Fire Service.

Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity—*[Interruption]* The Minister has not issued any Statement.

Mr Speaker, they are putting the officers in a very emotional manner. The landlords and landladies are harassing these officers for their rent. But today

they are telling us to believe that the dollar is down, inflation is down and interest rate is down, yet they cannot pay Ghana Immigration Service, they cannot pay Ghana Fire Service, and they cannot pay Ghana National Prison Service.

Mr Speaker, in the 2024 elections, my Colleagues—I am happy the Minister for Energy and Green Transition is here. He was one of the people who made a lot of, let me say, noise about their manifesto. In the NDC manifesto, page 99, teacher professional development and welfare, the H.E. John Dramani Mahama in the NDC told us that, Mr Speaker, with your permission, I read,

“the next NDC Government will place teachers at the heart of its education reforms. We will protect enhanced conditions of service, professional development, teacher welfare through the following initiatives.”

I was expecting H.E. John Dramani Mahama to tell us the state of the welfare of teachers in this country. But, Mr Speaker, he failed. Mr Speaker, one of the initiatives that they said they would do to improve the lives of teachers was that, “we will abolish teacher examination and integrate the licensing process into final year examination of trainees.”

Mr Speaker, where are we now? Today, training teachers have registered to write the licensure examinations that they promised that they would abolish. What is even surprising, they have increased their fees for registering for

licensure examination, something that they promised that they were going to abolish.

Mr Speaker, they went further to say that, “we will scrap the NPP mandatory national service for teacher trainee graduates and restore automatic employment for newly qualified teachers.”

6:45 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is so disheartening that they play with the emotion of our teachers. Mr Speaker, you went through a teacher, I went through a teacher, Hon Dafeamekpor went through a teacher, Hon Jinapor went through a teacher, so why are we disappointing our teachers this way?

Mr Speaker, I want to use this opportunity to tell His Excellency, John Dramani Mahama to organise a press conference at the Jubilee House, and use the opportunity to apologise to our teachers for disappointing and deceiving them.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** It is now the turn of Hon Frank Kwame Adu Jack. Hon, are you a Chairperson of the Committee? So, you have five minutes. Your time starts now.

**Mr John Kwame Adu Jack (NDC — Dormaa Central):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Let me use the opportunity to correct my name. My name is not Frank; I am John Kwame Adu Jack.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I just read what has been presented to me.

**Mr Adu Jack:** So, maybe it has to be put right.

Mr Speaker, I think that we all listened to the President on Friday. After listening to the President and relaxing in our seat, we can understand that, indeed, this is somebody who will always come up with the truth about the state of this nation.

I am saying so because one of the things I picked from him was the performance of our Ghanaian cedi. As it stands, I can see that the cedi, at the level we are, is around I think GH¢10.7 per dollar, as compared to around GH¢17.00 per dollar in some time past. This man delivered same to us that this is what he is able to do. I do not know why somebody was trying to downplay the cedi's appreciation to all the major foreign currencies.

I term the cedi appreciation as an invisible hand in our economy. I am saying so because one of the import-dependent countries in this world is Ghana. So, what happens is that we import almost everything, including even toothpicks. But one thing that changes the values of this at the ports is the exchange rate that we have.

Because at the period for which the exchange rate was GH¢17.00 to the dollar, if a person was importing an item that the person ought to pay an import duty of about, let us assume, GH¢17,000, paying the same duties and

taxes today, the person may pay about GH¢10,000. What that means is that with the exchange rate alone, one is taking back some amount that has not even been worked for. That is the main reason why I said I loved looking at the President when he was talking.

He said something profound. He said that for him, he was not prepared to arrest the dollar because it is difficult to arrest the dollar. Rather, what he was prepared to do was to strengthen the Ghanaian currency so that in its own power as the Ghanaian cedi, it fights against the dollar, and I think that is the right thing he has done. Because if a person is a boxing trainer, and then send their boxer to the arena and he is always being beating, I do not think the right thing is to just tie the hand of the other boxer so that the fighter will be able to get through.

But what one ought to do is to help the feeble hands and the blows of their fighter so that he will be able to defend him or herself without one coming on board to support at any point in time. That is what exactly the President and the team which I call “the team of good heads”—we had a team that we were told was a solid team, and they made mention of names that were solid. Unfortunately, by the end of the period, the solid team had an exchange rate of 17 per cent. But in our time, I am not saying the NDC is a solid team. In fact, solids are difficult to get into certain spaces, but we are more liquid than solid because we get into every space for us to be able to change the system. It does not matter what anybody thinks it is.

That is exactly how our President and the team, which is so liquid, have been able to penetrate throughout the economy to deal with the situations on the ground. Mr Speaker, let me use the opportunity to thank you.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, we want to do some variation and we need your leave to do so. Our Colleague, Nana Addo Kenneth, is engaging in some parliamentary duties outside of this Chamber and we would want to proceed to replace him with Nana Ampaw Addo-Frempong.

So, Mr Speaker, with that replacement done, I want to take your leave to exit the Chamber to discharge some other parliamentary duties. But I am cautioning the Majority Chief Whip, Mr Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor, he has a long name that available Leaders are not to become subject of his usual bully. This Side of the House—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Leader, nobody can bully anybody.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I just need to put this on record. This Side of the House, knows them. Even when a Minority Leader is speaking, they say contempt, everyday contempt, everyday contempt. Should we not speak? *Mma yen nkeka bi nkyere mo?* Mr Speaker, there will be more contempt in this House. We will speak and they should continue to remove all of us. They are going to remove all 87 of us and stay in this Chamber alone as a one-party Parliament. That is what they want.

Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip is very intolerant. He does not want to debate and he does not want divergent views. It is the reason I want to remind him that when he was in the Eighth Parliament, he said a lot of things. If we were to pursue him on contempt, would he have survived?

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Leader, thank you so much.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Every now and then, he behaves like a crying baby. Hon Dafeamekpor; him in particular. I am not talking about others.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Majority Leader, he is your friend.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Yes, Mr Speaker. It is the reason I am using that liberty of friendship to tell him my piece of mind. Yes, I want to go for the third contempt. Mr Speaker, he may respond to me.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** No, he would not respond.

**Mr Rockson Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, we thank the Leader for his comments. If we may continue with the debates.

6:55 p.m.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. Hon Afenyo-Markin, do you see? Look at the way Hon John Jinapor is looking at you. Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Ralph Poku-Adusei for his comments. You have five minutes.

**Mr Ralph Poku-Adusei (NPP — Bekwai):** Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation delivered by His Excellency the President on Friday. Before I proceed, permit me to set some parameters clearly. I am unable to understand whether what was delivered by the President is consistent with Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution. Simply because, when we take the whole three-hour Statement delivered by the President, there is nothing about it which indicates that that is the true state of this nation, today.

Mr Speaker, it saddens me so much because we had high expectations, but it is a total deviation from what the state of this nation is. I will prove to the Members on the other Side that a message on the state of the nation is not an avenue to improve upon their manifesto. The message on the state of the nation is not an avenue to improve upon their 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. It is an avenue to tell Ghanaians the truth about the state of this nation.

And that is not what we heard or what we saw on that fateful Friday. I have been so confused that to date, I am still wondering whether it was a public lecture, whether it was an enhancement of the manifesto, or whether it was a campaign promise. I will leave it there.

Mr Speaker, let me move straight to why I say this. If we take the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Minister for Finance was here, at page 80, paragraph 573, and I will quote:

“Mr Speaker, the Labour Department conducted 1,085 workplace inspections, registered 528 compensation cases, and placed 9,553 job seekers in employment...”

Mr Speaker, my emphasis is on 9,553 jobseekers in employment. This was the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Today, we have the President, on page 13, looking into the eyes of Ghanaians and telling us that they have created over 1 million jobs. Mr Speaker, why? Is there no fear of God in human beings anymore? It is frightening because the reality is that they have not created any jobs, and they owe it to Ghanaians to say they are sorry, for the whole of 2025, they did not create any jobs, then we will forgive them.

Mr Speaker, once again, let me move into the economy. They go on at length, using jargon upon jargon, about macroeconomic indicators. One question to the President before I land is: Where is the purchasing power? Today, if inflation is low and one does not have money in their pocket, what has he done to us? Today, the dollar is down, but if we do not have money in our pockets, what has he done?

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I want to urge the President to come back again and deliver the true Message on the State of the Nation to the people of Ghana.

I thank you for this opportunity.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Let me now turn to Hon Dr Thomas Anabah-



Winsum. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

**Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah (NDC — Garu):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation delivered by His Excellency President John Dramani Mahama to the House. Before I proceed, I would like to correct Colleagues on the other Side that there is a publication and a release from the Ministry of the Interior that states:

“The Ministry of the Interior wishes to inform the public, particularly persons of the Ghana Prisons Service, Ghana National Fire Service, the Ghana Immigration Service, that the Government has released funds for the payment of outstanding rent for the year 2025.”

Have you heard? Stop the conjecture! Let me tell them one important thing. Friends from the other Side are asking whether the Statement the President made on the Message on the State of the Nation was apt? Let me tell them what the Message on the State of the Nation really is: it gives a platform for the President to inform Parliament and citizens about the country’s current economic, social, and political status. In addition, it also highlights the Government’s achievements, outlines future policies, and fosters national unity.

That is what the Message on the State of the Nation is about, and that is exactly what the President did. He told us what he has achieved in one year, he told us

what he is going to do in the future, and he asked for unity and even pleaded with doctors to try to be more patriotic and accept posting to very vulnerable communities.

Mr Speaker, I would want to comment on the social aspects and achievements of the Government and what we proposed to do. That is to talk about the Health Sector because it is said that a country that is healthy is a wealthy country. The Government, seeing this, knows very well that 70 per cent of our health needs are in the primary area.

So, the Government is targeting primary health care, where he is trying to work diligently with his team to ensure that the universal health coverage is achieved by 2030, with measures that he has put in place. Let me list them: The Government is building primary health care, two Community-based Health Planning and Services (CHPS) compounds for every district for four years. That means eight CHPS compounds in four years. That is to bring health care to the doorsteps of the people.

The Government is also making sure that the national health insurance coverage is increased. Therefore, for now, we have already reached 66 per cent of all Ghanaians, and more are still registering because now there is confidence in the national health insurance that is to ensure that we achieve the universal health coverage and augment service delivery at the primary care level. This is because the money meant for national health insurance their government capped it,

and spent on whatever they wanted, and people started neglecting national health insurance.

Now, a Government that is *aban papa* has come. He has made sure the national health insurance has liquidity to ensure that they even beg providers to come for their money. That is the Government we are talking about. I am going on to let you understand that the inequity that exists in our health delivery sector, by building CHPS compounds and ensuring primary health care, the inequity will disappear. In that way, we will achieve what we call the universal health coverage.

Moving on to the disease pattern, the burden of disease in Ghana right now is non-communicable diseases, which is 40 per cent, and this started not today. About seven years ago, non-communicable diseases started shooting up, but we never saw any efforts from their government when they were in power. But this Government has come; what has it done? One, it has created what we call the MahamaCares, the Ghana Medical Trust Fund to ensure that we equip our hospitals to be able to deliver and take care of chronic disease patients suffering from non-communicable diseases.

The other important thing he has done is that the needed human resources to manage non-communicable diseases which are specialised nurses and doctors—What has the Government done? That is what the Government is telling them, so that the people will be assured of what they are doing and be

comforted that the future is in the good hands of a political team.

7:05 p.m.

He has also made sure that we enhance the training of nurses to specialise nurses in cardiology, nephrology, oncology, and endocrinology. [*Hear! Hear!*] In addition, emergency services and critical care services which they neglected, which is causing no bed syndrome and the rest, the Government is ensuring that we train more nurses and doctors in emergency medicine so that the next time you are sick, you fall on to our hospitals and not to fly abroad for treatment. Besides that, he is equipping all our hospitals—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, wind up please. Your time is up.

Dr Anabah, sorry for taking five seconds of your time.

**Dr Anabah:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I will be happy to conclude. Let me tell them that this Government is investing in health, approaching the Abuja Declaration, which is 15 per cent. In 2021, they invested 7 per cent in health; in 2022, 7.6 per cent; in 2023, 6.7 per cent. In 2026, we are investing 11 per cent. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** So, let me now invite Hon Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

**Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, the President gave the Message on the State of the Nation and he told Ghanaians that the economy was in a take-off mode. He urged Ghanaians to buckle their seatbelts. But the plane is not taking off. We are stuck in a narrow runway. The aircraft has not left the ground. The economic doctrine that is driving policy has a narrow and reactive approach.

Mr Speaker, what is happening now is that the managers of this economy are buying gold. They are turning gold into dollars. They are injecting their dollar liquidity into the foreign exchange market and then building reserves to defend the cedi. That is all that the managers of this economy are doing. This is currency management, not structural transformation. The real sectors being industry, manufacturing, oil and gas, are weakening because policy bandwidth is diverted to short-term stabilisation and reserve stockpiling. Investment and productivity sectors are weak. That is why we are stuck on the runway and this plane is not flying.

Mr Speaker, I will give you some statistics from the Ghana Statistical Service and I will give you up to quarter three of 2025. This is where data is publicly available and we will see that this economy is being run in a narrow bandwidth. Mr Speaker, if you take GDP growth, momentum has been slow. If you look at quarter three of 2024, real

GDP growth rates year on year has been 7 per cent. For quarter three of 2025, real GDP growth rate reduced to 5.5 per cent from 7 per cent. This is the narrow bandwidth that the Government is doing. This reflects 1.5 per cent decline and equivalent to 21 per cent slowdown in growth momentum. Mr Speaker, growth is slowing.

If you go to industry, Mr Speaker, which is key to this country, quarter three of 2024, growth rate was 11.4 per cent. If you go to the same period, quarter three of 2025, from 11.4 per cent, it has reduced to 0.8 per cent. This is the economy that is being managed and we want the plane to fly. This is a collapse of 10.6 percentage points and a 90 per cent drop in growth momentum. Industry is the backbone of this economy. If growth is reducing from 11.4 per cent to 0.8 per cent, we should be crying as a country.

Mr Speaker, manufacturing, half speed, that is where we are. Manufacturing should be the engine of this country. That is what the Akufo-Addo Government said. When we brought 1D1F, we said we were going to process all this produce. Manufacturing should be the engine of this economy. Manufacturing has reduced. For quarter three of 2024, 7.4 per cent growth. For quarter three of 2025, it has reduced to 3.9 per cent growth. This tells us that this economy has slowed down. We are over-focusing on building reserves.

Mr Speaker, oil and gas has contracted by 18.2 per cent. This is shrinking. This is the economy—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Let me now come to the Chairperson of the Committee on Roads and Transportation, Hon Adjei Mensah. You have 10 minutes.

**Mr Isaac Adjei Mensah (NDC — Wassa East):** Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion.

Mr Speaker, allow me also to commend the President for that wonderful presentation and if there is any time that a Message on the State of the Nation had been presented by a sitting President, it was last Friday. It was full of truthfulness. It was accurate. It was full of satisfaction, and I could see in the faces of our Colleagues on the other Side that they listened with rapt attention. They were indeed mesmerised. Even when this man was presenting the Message on the State of the Nation in humility, his composure and everything—So when they took the cocoa pods in their hands, especially, when he was on the road sector, they were all listening with rapt attention.

Mr Speaker, this is a man who, when he was talking about road, he did that at a time without any emotions, because we were in this country where for eight years, we had several prescriptions for our roads: Year of Roads 1, Year of Roads 2, Year of Roads 3, but we do not have anything to show.

Mr Speaker, I say that the presentation in respect of road sector was satisfactory because I have been monitoring all the FM stations, and I have never cited any

negative comments regarding the road sector. This is a President who inherited over GH¢104 billion in total commitment of the road sector.

He never lamented. Debt to contractors, over GH¢21 billion, he never lamented, except for him to start paying the debt. As we speak, over GH¢10 billion have been paid to contractors. These moneys were those that we inherited from the NPP Administration, and the Minister for Finance has been instructed to ensure that these payments are done, and it is ongoing.

Mr Speaker, the President was very clear in his prescription on how the condition of our roads can be improved, and that is where we have the Big Push. The President was very clear that 50 major roads have been placed under the Big Push Programme.

7:15 p.m.

These major roads touch every part of this country, the 16 regions, and I could see in the face of our Colleagues, they are all nodding their heads because they have these roads in all their areas. Mr Speaker, about 21 major roads that were given out on contracts by the previous administration had also been added to the Big Push Agenda and that is 23 major roads costing over GH¢15 billion. So, the 50 projects that have been given out also cost about GH¢50 billion so together, about GH¢65 billion has been invested in the road sector. And with the 50 major roads, they are in various stages of progression and by the end of 2028,

we will see what is actually in there. This is very commendable and I expect my Colleagues to commend the President for this wonderful performance.

Mr Speaker, the President was very clear putting life into existing roads. The Tema Motorway was talked about and according to the President, of which records are there to show, the project is now 32 per cent complete. On this road, we have four lanes here and there, and the external three lanes also going through. In Tetteh Quarshie, it was very clear that the road is going to be remodeled to the level of modernity.

Mr Speaker, the President was very clear—and that is why I expect a commendation from the New Patriotic Party (NPP). The Accra-Kumasi Expressway is going to be one of the best networks in Africa, shortening travel time to Kumasi by two or 2.5 hours and from Accra to Kumasi is about 198.7 kilometres. That is going to be President Mahama's legacy. The last time I was talking about this, I said that road should be named after President Mahama as Mahama Expressway. [*Hear! Hear!*] The assurance is also that the existing road is still being attended to, and that is what we need. We are bringing modernity into the whole scheme.

Mr Speaker, it is also important to be honest with ourselves. President Mahama has made it very clear. The Minister has been instructed by Cabinet to ensure that by the end of the year, there will be a working toll booth. Mr Speaker, in the transport infrastructure sector, the President assured us, and it is

very clear that he is putting life into the aviation sector. Now, plans are underway to establish the Ghana airline.

I was very amazed when I took the Kenyan Airways when going to Ethiopia and in Rwanda also, they have an airline and that is why it is important that the President gets this thing done and the understanding is that plans are underway. Mr Speaker, the President was very clear that we are remodeling the Terminal 2 and Terminal 3 together. Someone was even telling me that Abuja cannot compare themselves to Terminal 3. It was President Mahama who brought it.

He is going to remodel it into a seven to eight-layer car park will all be there and so the Terminal 2 will have the local and international linkages going through as well. But that is not the end, it was very clear that in improving the aviation space, the Sunyani, Bolgatanga and Wa Airports are going to come on board so this is a man who is very truthful in his presentation. And I saw in the faces of our Colleagues that they were all nodding with rapt attention and that is why I said I would like to thank the President for that wonderful presentation.

Mr Speaker, with all these major roads, one of the major roads I want to take the opportunity to talk about is the Suame Interchange. Some of our Colleagues talked about it, and they said that it has been reduced from four to two. It has not been reduced but there is rather a proposal for it to be reduced to three.

The roundabout goes to every direction; the second tier is the Suame to Kejetia and the third tier is Abrepo to Krofrom. It is the fourth tier that has a challenge because it will have major impact on many properties around. And that is why the outer ringway of Kumasi was introduced by President Mahama and that innovative measure costs us over GH¢4 billion. This means that over GH¢4 billion is invested in the Kumasi outer ring road. This is the Atiah Junction through to Sunyani, going to Tano Odumase, and back to Obom to the N10. Mr Speaker, that is what the President has for the country.

So, Mr Speaker, the President was very clear and some of the middle roads Tepa, Maabang, Goaso, Kumasi bypass and the Suame interchange I talked about. Tema outer ring road, Accra-Aflao dualisation, Cape Coast–Takoradi dualisation, and many more.

So, if we visit the FM stations and you monitor the TV stations, I have never cited any negative comments on this one so, I think it is something that we need to commend the President for that matter. Mr Speaker, it is also important to note that the President also talked about modernising the railways. The western and eastern railways to be modernised, to be able to carry the ore and manganese from Awaso, Nyinahin all the way to Takoradi.

Mr Speaker, the most important thing is also the bridges that have been touched. The Kumasi inner ring road bridge, the Volivo bridge, the Dambai bridge, and Adowso bridge have also

been reported as going to be done and done properly. And, of course, I talked about the toll road which by the end of the year, the toll road would have been brought to speed.

Mr Speaker, it is also important to know this, this is a man who is of truth. His nature is full of truthfulness. His nature, disposition and everything of his must be commended. Mr Speaker, it is all about the transport sector. We are aware of the recent challenges. Three hundred buses have been procured, 100 of which will come in very soon, and to augment the freight system in the country and I think that it is something that we must all commend.

I have had an occasion to go to some FM stations with their people, and what they have told me is that this is something that we must all support and support appropriately. But, of course, the railways, as we have talked about, is something that is up to speed, and we must all commend it accordingly. The ports and the 24-Hour Economy is also something that he talked about.

Mr Speaker, in concluding, I want to take the opportunity again to commend the President for that wonderful presentation. Thank you so very much. *[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. So let me now turn to Hon Frank Asiedu Bekoe. *[Uproar]* Your Colleagues are already calling you so you have the floor. Give it to your Colleagues.

**Mr Frank Asiedu Bekoe (NPP — Suhum):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this treasured space to take a bite on the Message on the State of the Nation, 2026 and I congratulate the President for a constitutional obligation under Article 67. But, indeed, the President for the past one year has been making bad choices. In February 2025, all the President did is to authorise his Chief of Staff to revoke the appointment of over 30,000 young men and women of our country. I thought that the President would have reported on this matter because unemployment is a national security threat. And since the President failed to report on this matter, I think that Ghanaians should be told the truth.

Indeed, Presidents are elected to solve problems. President Mahama in 2024 promised one-three-three. Now, President Mahama comes here and he is shying away from one-three-three. I did not hear one-three-three from H.E. the President.

I thought that the President was coming to tell us that the 24-Hour Economy has created certain jobs. Indeed, we go to the Jubilee House and at 5:30 p.m. they have closed. We see only security men at the Jubilee House. I thought they would do one-three-three at the Jubilee House. Indeed, the President has been making bad choices.

Indeed, for over 14 months, Immigration Officers, Prison Officers, Fire Service—men and women in uniform had their allowances not paid by this President. I thought that President Mahama on Friday would have spoken

on this matter but the President failed. He failed to address this issue to the Ghanaian people. Indeed, the President has been making bad choices.

The President has been making bad choices because we have over 74,000 to 100,000 nurses and midwives who have not been employed. I thought the President would have addressed that matter to the Ghanaian people. Indeed, the President has been making bad choices. The President came here and told us that from quarter one to quarter three of 2025, over one million jobs were created only to contradict the Ghana Statistical Service. I want to ask Mr President: where are the 670,000 ghost jobs?

7:25 p.m.

Because this is contradicting what the Statistical Service is saying and I think that President Mahama and his Government should apologise to the Ghanaian people for misleading us because this is a palpable falsehood that the President came to tell us.

Mr Speaker, I cannot speak without talking about cocoa farmers. Those in Suhum, Kwabena Kumi, Akorabo, Nankese and Aponoapono are dying because the President has made them poorer. The President, after coming to meet GH¢3,100 per bag, has made the Ghanaian cocoa farmer poorer by paying GH¢2,587. And to add insult to injury—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Let me look at the list. Hon John Dumelo. You are a Minister of State, so you have 10 minutes.

**Deputy Minister for Food and Agriculture (Mr John Setor Dumelo) (MP):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I want to comment on the beautiful speech that our President gave on Friday, a speech of hope, a speech of true vision, and I must commend him for that wonderful speech.

It is important to note that my Colleagues on the other Side have said they did not understand it, but I can understand why they did not understand, because what is in the Message of the State of the Nation is something they have never heard before. They are overwhelmed by the number of things we are doing, the number of things that we are continuing to do and the number of things that we will do at the end of 2028, and so I can understand them.

But on a more serious note, a couple of months ago, the President launched the Agriculture for Economic Transformation Agenda. What is that about? It is an all-year-round farming, and all-year-round farming means that we want to keep our prices stable, feed the industry, export the rest, but most importantly, create jobs. My Brother, Hon “Protozoa”, asked where the jobs are. I will show him where the jobs are in a few minutes.

The second one is that last week, I took a tour of the North, and for the first time, there has been a pepper glut in Zaare in the Upper East Region, which has never happened before in a very long time.

Why is that possible? Because farmers now have hope, farmers now believe in President Mahama and the Agricultural Economic Transformation Agenda, and that is why there is a glut of pepper for the first time in the dry season in the North. What we are hoping to do by the end of this year is to ensure that tomato also comes on board, and that is exactly what is happening.

I went to Garu in the Upper East Region, and for the first time as well, farmers are producing tomatoes in commercial quantities, but not to feed the rest of the country. But I can tell you that in the next two years, most of the tomato traders will stop going to Burkina Faso because Ghanaian farmers will start producing tomatoes in commercial quantities.

When we come to Akomadan in the Ashanti Region, they are doing trials in tomato varieties. Cobra and Sika varieties are what are being replicated there. When we go to the Veia Dam, the left bank and right bank, they are rehabilitating it. Why? Because farmers now have renewed hope in President Mahama and renewed hope in the NDC Government. And I can say for a fact that these farmers are not going to lose hope. Why? Because we are resetting the Ghanaian economy, and we are resetting agriculture in the right direction. So, it is rather understandable that some of them are unable to understand.

Again, even when we go to the North, we have Tamne Irrigation Dam, the Veia West Bank, Akomadan, the 250 solar water pumps that we are distributing, and



there are *galamsey* water pumps that we seized, which have been distributed across the country, which is producing all these wonderful results that are coming about. And so I can understand why my Colleagues on the other Side, do not understand what is going on. What is going on is the reset agenda, and that reset agenda is something that we are moving forward in the right direction.

Also, for the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete*, when we take the whole value chain, we have those who are hatching the day-old chicks, those brooding the day-old chicks, those transporting the day-old chicks, those providing the vaccines, and those watching over those brooding the day-old chicks. That is all job creation.

And so when they get up to where the one million jobs are, I can tell them that every district and every constituency in this country has a farmer who is brooding 10,000 birds, and that is job creation. If each farmer is employing five people, calculate that, and let me see. I can understand that their phone is dead, and so they cannot calculate. No, I am giving an example of just how *Nkoko Nketenkete* is helping create jobs.

The second one is that we are distributing 10,000 birds across all the constituencies, and I can tell they have received their birds, have they not? The birds are in their constituency. But, ladies and gentlemen, the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* is creating a lot of jobs. So far, eight regions are brooding the birds. We have completed distribution in five regions across the country.

And I can say for a fact that we are almost done with the Greater Accra Region, we have finished the Eastern Region, we have done Bono East and the Ashanti Region, and so *wompɛ wei na wo pɛ dɛn* to wit, if you do not like this, then what do you like. Tell me. So, the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* is creating jobs. Even those who are administering the vaccines alone, it is about job creation. And I can tell you for a fact that those who have the birds now are happy, because as soon as they are done with the birds, they are able to sell them and make more money.

Apart from that, I would entreat my Colleagues on the other Side to build a chicken coop, because we are distributing 80,000 birds to 50 commercial farmers across the country. So, this is a time for them to be commercial farmers. This is the time for them to get into poultry. This is the time for them to be entrepreneurs. This is the time to get into agriculture. Because we believe in the Ghana that we want. We believe in the administration of John Dramani Mahama.

Last but not least, it is about the glut. Last week, I took a trip from Nalerigu to Nakpanduri to Garu to Zebilla to Bolga to Navrongo to Tumu to Jirapa to Wa. Then I ended up at Afadjato South District.

7:35 p.m.

All these farmers have maize that they are storing. But guess what? There is hope for them. The hope is that they should not despair because the Buffer Stock has GHC300 million to buy all of them.

The second one is that this year, it is very likely that we will give free fertilisers to all the farmers across this country, and that is what would be able to cushion the farmers. There are no buyers; we are the buyers. We will buy them; we will buy the maize, the rice, the tomatoes, and the pepper.

We are building factories across the country to add value to all the things that the farmers are producing. This is the best time to be a farmer in this country. This is the best time to get into agro-processing, and that is where the jobs are. We are creating most of the jobs in the agricultural sector.

So, Mr Speaker, I would beg my Friend Mr Bekoe in the name of God, if he does not have a chicken coop, he should start building one because we will give him jobs. We would give them *Nkokɔ Nketenkete*, and we will make sure that this Easter they celebrate and celebrate it well. We will make sure that they celebrate Christmas and celebrate it well. We will also make sure that their constituency is able to create jobs.

Thank you so much, Mr Speaker. God bless you and God bless Ghana. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much, Hon John Dumelo. It is now the turn of Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh. Are you the Ranking Member because they have written 10 minutes for you?

**Mr Richard Acheampong:** Mr Speaker, he is not a Ranking Member, so he is speaking for five minutes.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Nana Asafo-Adjei, you have five minutes.

**Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho):**

“Mr Speaker, I am humbled by Ghana’s elections as the first Vice-Chairman of the African Union at the 39<sup>th</sup> Ordinary Session of the AU Assembly of the Heads of States of Government held in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia. It is also gratifying to note that my Colleagues Leaders in West Africa, have declared me, John Dramani Mahama, the region sole candidate for the position of the chairmanship of the African Union when the rotation chairmanship returns to West Africa in 2027.”

Mr Speaker, I would want to place on record that President John Dramani Mahama was never elected as a Vice-Chairperson of the African Union.

Mr Speaker, the African Head of State never gave him that note. Mr Speaker, now let me take you through this. The African Union Commission has what we call the Bureau of the African Assembly of Heads of States.

Mr Speaker, let me explain to you. We have five blocks in the African continent. We have the Chairperson, the first Vice, the second Vice, the third Vice, and then the Rapporteur. Mr

Speaker, this is what happens. It is rotational every year. Now, when one assumes the position of the Chairperson, the first Vice, the second Vice, the third Vice, they move hierarchically. So, when a country wants to step in, they step in from the third Vice position.

Mr Speaker, in 2023, Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo lobbied the African President and lobbied African Union, and he got elected into the Bureau as the third Vice-Chairman of the African Bureau of Heads of States. So, this is what happens. In 2024, Ghana will become the third Vice-Chair of the African Union. In 2025, Ghana will become the second Vice-Chair because of the progression. In 2027, Ghana automatically becomes the Chairman, and then the Chairman becomes the Rapporteur. It rotates like that.

Mr Speaker, I have this evidence to put here. This is on the website. In the 2024 African Union Heads of the Bureau, Ghana was the third Vice-Chair, held by Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. In 2025, Ghana was the second Vice-Chair. In 2026, John Dramani Mahama would be the first Vice-Chair. It moves like that. So, Mr Speaker, John Dramani Mahama was never elected in Addis Ababa. He only progressed in the Bureau as a result of Nana Addo's foundation that he had laid.

Mr Speaker, I move to my second point. Let me place on record that the passport application in Ghana is never 24 hours. It has never run 24 hours before. No aspect of the passport

application in Ghana is running 1-3-3; never.

Mr Speaker, no area or no procedure in our passport application process. Even the earliest time a person can get it is when they do an expedited action. In the expedited passport application, quite recently, the Minister also placed a closure or indefinite hold on the expedited action. So, a person cannot apply for a passport in Ghana and get it within three weeks, as he said. It is a lie; it is never happening. It goes beyond that. Let the President be clear and straightforward; it is false.

Mr Speaker, it is sad that we are only having rhetoric as against results in this country—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hold on. Did he say it is a lie? If he did say that—Hon Nana, please choose another word instead of “lying”.

**Mr Ayeh:** Mr Speaker, respectfully, I take a guide. I mean, I cannot say that the President lied. Respectfully, I cannot say that. I withdraw, Mr Speaker, and I take your guidance.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, he has withdrawn.

**Mr Ayeh:** Mr Speaker, the President misled the House. Mr Speaker, now, is it not ironic to hear the National Democratic Congress (NDC) when the cedi is artificially appreciated against the dollar? It is assumed to be the prudent economic management of the NDC. But, Mr Speaker, when the Bank of Ghana is

making losses, for that one, it is the doing of the New Patriotic Party (NPP)

Mr Speaker, when fuel at the global market is down, by its inference, and fuel prices in Ghana are low, it is the doing of the NDC. They are—*[Interruption]*

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Ayeh, I cannot stop you. It is automatic. All right; I will give you five seconds. Hon Members, I did interrupt. *[Interruption]* So, I would just allow five seconds.

**Mr Ayeh:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. When the fuel is coming down, it is the doing of the NDC, but, when cocoa prices are going down, that one is the doing of the NPP.

Mr Speaker, when inflation figures are going down, it is the doing of the NDC, but when electricity tariffs are going high, that is the doing of the NPP—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you so much.

Hon Ghansah, let me hear you. You have five minutes.

**Alhaji Alhassan Kobina Ghansah (NDC — Asikuma/Odoben/Brakwa):** Thank you Mr Speaker, for allowing me to comment on the Message on the State of the Nation that was beautifully presented by H.E John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, I was very sad when, last Friday, the Minority brought cocoa to the House to do politics with it. Indeed, the pricing of cocoa is done by the producer

price review committee, which comprises the Minister of Finance, the Bank of Ghana, the Farmers' Representative, Local Buying Companies (LBCs) and the Cocoa Board (COCOBOD).

So COCOBOD is just a stakeholder in the pricing of cocoa. Then the price is also determined by the world market price and the exchange rates. The exchange rate also plays an important role in pricing cocoa. During their time, the exchange rate was around GHC17 to the dollar. Is it true or not? **[Some Hon Members: True]** But with the pragmatic measures put in place by the Ministry of Finance and the Bank of Ghana, the exchange rate was brought down. I was very happy when the President made some remarks to the effect that we did not arrest the dollar and give it to IGP, yet we were able to appreciate the cedi.

Now, somebody asked, granted that COCOBOD had some crisis at the moment, na who cause am?

Mr Speaker, when we were leaving office in 2016, we had a positive equity of GHC1.8 billion. When they were leaving in 2024, they left a negative equity of GHC3.9 billion. **[Some Hon Members: Eiii!]**

7:45 p.m.

**Alhaji Ghansah:** Mr Speaker, we inherited GHC32.91 billion debt when we came.

Mr Speaker, somebody said NDC has deceived the cocoa farmers. But I am proving to them that when we took over

and the cedi appreciated, the world market price was US\$7,200. So, we were able to bring down the exchange rates, and then when we applied the 70 per cent, we arrived at a price of GH¢3,280. We added GH¢180 to the price. Along the line, we saw that the exchange rate went up a little to about GH¢11. We calculated and added about 400 to it, and the producer price came to GH¢3,600. Is it true or not? [**Some Hon Member:** True.]

**Alhaji Ghansah:** It means when it is going up, we also calculate and then go up. But at the moment—

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, it is now the turn of Hon Kwabena Boateng. Hon Member, you are a Ranking Member? He is the Deputy Ranking? All right. He has five minutes.

**Mr Kwabena Boateng (NPP — Ejisu):** Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to have a say in respect of the Message on the State of the Nation delivered by the President last Friday. Mr Speaker, let me also commend Mr President for discharging the constitutional imperative pursuant to Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution.

Mr Speaker, we on this Side of the House had an expectation prior to the presentation by Mr President. The expectation was that we expected the President to have come with some sobriety, for want of a better word, a certain level of honesty in respect of our true state as a country.

Mr Speaker, that will enable us on this Side and also the people of Ghana to appreciate our situation so that we cannot jaw-jaw and proffer, even from this Side, superior ideas and options for the development of this country. We were not expecting the President to be garnishing the state of the nation; some level of embellishment, some level of surface painting, and some level of gaslighting as well. That was not our expectation at all.

But Mr Speaker, be it as it is, we know that as the people of Ghana, the verdict on the true state of affairs is with us. The verdict of the actual state of this country is with us. The verdict is reflective in our pockets, so we know. The verdict is reflective in the marketplaces, so we know very well where we are as a country.

The people of Ghana presently are suffering a heartbreak. That heartbreak is emanating from a plethora of promises that were made by the NDC Government to the people of Ghana. Mr Speaker, the litany of promises that were made to romanticise the people of Ghana, based on which they also donated their votes massively to the NDC Government. Mr Speaker, as we speak, those promises have been jettisoned. They have been abandoned. The Government is no longer pursuing them, and it has occasioned a great deal of disappointment and heartbreak for the people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, how can I comment without mentioning cocoa prices as a son of a cocoa farmer? The cocoa farmers of

our country today are wallowing in deep poverty. They have been left in abject poverty. The only reason we are told that the cocoa farmer cannot get what he deserves is that prices have gone down in the international market. Mr Speaker, as individuals, we do not even want to befriend people who only want to benefit from a relationship and would not also want to reciprocate.

How will Government want to benefit from the profit of cocoa when the prices are up in the international market, but then when the prices come down in the international market, Government does not want to support the cocoa farmer? That is a one-sided beneficial relationship and that cannot be good. If Government benefits from the profit when the prices are high, Government must be ready to support the poor cocoa farmer when the prices also decline. That is how the relationship should be, mutual benefit. Mr Speaker, as we speak, we cannot say that the relationship Government is seeking to establish with the cocoa farmer is one that is—

7:55 p.m.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Kwabena Boateng, as much as I was enjoying your delivery, that is what the time could give you.

So, let us turn to Hon Emmanuel Kwaku Boam. Hon Member, you have five minutes.

**Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (NDC — Pru-East):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. I would like to seize this opportunity to thank His Excellency for such a

wonderful delivery and being fair on the true state of what we are seeing here in Ghana.

I want to tell my Friends on the other Side that they have done well by telling us what they think about the state of the nation. But unfortunately, they keep telling the people of Ghana things that they are not seeing, things that have happened over the years. Today, Ghanaians have felt the better side of it.

The Minority tells us that “Economics, *yɛ di?*” What happens to macroeconomics? The Leader said that. He said, “*Na macroeconomics na yɛ be di ada?*”, which means that are we going to eat macroeconomics? I want to take a few minutes of the time, Mr Speaker and explain to the people of Ghana that everything we are seeing here is out of the economics of prudent men who are managing the economy of this country. Some years ago, the whole economy was broken down to the point that inflation rose all the way to 54.1 per cent.

An Hon Member from the other Side said that we are saying the economy is good, yet we do not have the purchasing power. How would we have the purchasing power when some time ago they eroded the benefits of the gains of this economy?

Today, we are telling them that, that 54 per cent has been brought to 3.8 per cent. In fact, they should be clapping for His Excellency. They said they had the men, but today, we want to tell them that we have the real men. They have been able to manage the economy to bring it to a

level where the ordinary Ghanaian still appreciates what is happening on the market.

Mr Speaker, we walk to the market today, items that were worth over GH¢1,000 two years ago, today, the same value of money could buy two or three of such items. It tells us that the Ghanaian today has appreciated value for his money than two or three years ago, when we said that when the fundamentals are weak, the exchange rate is going to expose it.

Today, the exchange rate has exposed the good fundamentals that have been built by the good men and the people who are running this country. The Minority should applaud us for that. The fact that they are in Minority should not stop them from telling the truth at least. They should be able to award us that credibility for having managed the economy prudently.

Today, as we speak, the ordinary driver who buys fuel in his car for a whole day of roaming and working is able to save a lot of funds. When he does that for about five days or within the week, he is saving about GH¢5,000. If this is not prudent management of the economy, what else would we say this is? What else do we do? Ghanaians are already happy with us and in fact, they would wish that NDC would be in government forever.

Unlike some time ago when we were sloganeering and saying that we had the men, we were saying that we were doing everything, agenda whatever, One

District, One Factory (1D1F), with all the slogans we gave, the ordinary Ghanaians could not see what we are seeing today.

Today, the Government is tackling corruption and we can all see. The Minister for Finance has managed to do a lot of things to bring appreciation that the good people of Ghana, about 950,000 of these people have been alleviated and been pushed up from the line of poverty.

Mr Speaker, I know time would not allow me, but I would like to tell the people of Ghana that the Message on the State of the Nation is indeed the true state that we are seeing. Whatever we are seeing and feeling is indeed the work of the good people who are in the realm of affairs managing our economy. To the point that they manage it using every systematic approach to ensure that every cedi that the Government is putting into anything —

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we will take the last round. One on each Side. We will take, firstly, Hon Addo-Frempong. You have five minutes.

**Nana Ampaw Kwame Addo-Frempong (NPP — Abuakwa North):** Mr Speaker, I am a Vice Chairperson.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Per the arrangement, Vice Chairpersons and Deputy Ranking Members have five minutes. It is only Chairpersons and Ministers.

**Mr Addo-Frempong:** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to

contribute to the Message on the State of the Nation as delivered by the President.

Mr Speaker, what was presented to us in this House was nothing but a story of acclamation and then also apportioning of blame. Development must follow logic. At all times, development must bring relief to the people. Why do I say this? I am saying emphatically that this Side of the House do not support the construction of a new expressway at this time. The emphasis is on at this time. The reason is that already, there is an existing infrastructure, which the NDC took charge of at 70 per cent completion. There are other pertinent problems in the road and transport sector, which we must also consider. A Member on the other Side, the Hon Member for Zabzugu, made a Statement on the floor of this House, telling us that Accra is congested.

Mr Speaker, there is a research group by name Gilma Research. Just last month, they published research to tell us that Ghana is losing GHC4.5 billion annually due to congestion in the capital. The President himself, at a function in Dodowa last year, during his “thank you” tour, told the world that Accra is overstretched, overpopulated and the roads are congested. In his solution to that, he said that he was even thinking about moving the capital town from Accra somewhere to the Accra plains because it is overpopulated. Mr Speaker, yet we did not find any policy on what Mr President spoke about.

I want to Side with the Hon Member from Zabzugu, that it is about time we

lay emphasis and focus on light rail transport. We do not have to waste time constructing a whole new expressway just because according to the Chairperson for the Committee on Roads and Transportation, we should even name it after the President. If Mr President wants edifices to be named after him, there are several of them around. We do not need to construct a road with the current infrastructure we have, that is the Accra to Kumasi. With the sort of improvements that the previous government started, if this Government should conclude that, trust me, it will solve the problem this new expressway is to solve.

Mr Speaker, let me come to cocoa. Cocoa farmers in Abuakwa North, Kukurantumi and Old Tafo are very angry with the state of this nation. The President, during his campaign, when he was Candidate, Mahama told us that when he becomes President again, one cocoa farm, one borehole. He became President and we wake up the next morning, he is slashing prices of cocoa. This is unacceptable. The President and the Government must apologise to farmers. At the end of the day, they have not brought any policy to improve yields. Lives are being lost as a result of this price slash.

Mr Speaker, the least said about the Nkoko Nketenketete Policy, the better. I have not sighted any policy document in this House explaining when is to be done and how is to be done. We have the President telling us that they have distributed 720 *nkoko* to 13,000 farmers. What kind of mathematical model is



that? We are interested in knowing the mathematical model the President used.

8:05 p.m.

What is even worse is that we have an officer at the Office of the President in charge of our agriculture and agribusiness telling us that indeed 2,500 is greater than and bigger than 3,600. Mr Speaker, what sort of logical mathematics is that?

In conclusion, I want to state emphatically that cocoa affairs are in shambles, graduate and youth unemployment is on the rise, and our priorities in the road sector are totally misplaced. Let the Government reconsider all these things and give us the true state of the nation. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Hon Emmanuel Drah is the last person for the day.

**Mr Emmanuel Drah (NDC — Upper West Akim):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to debate on the Motion on the Floor. Mr Speaker, the President of the Republic of Ghana presented to this House the Message on the State of the Nation on 27<sup>th</sup> February, 2026. In his Statement, the President mentioned that we are going to control Government expenses through fiscal consolidation policies using an expenditure-based approach.

Mr Speaker, as part of the reform, the President indicated that we are going to

ensure that there are policies to control Government spending, and this is one of the strategies by doing away with nuisance taxes such as the E-levy, betting tax, and others, and we have sustainably maintained that. We are going to control Government spending, according to the President, and this is leading to the birth of the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026, which will soon be laid before the House for consideration.

Mr Speaker, according to the President, the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026, when approved, will have some three basic functions. First of all, this office is going to ensure pre-contract award review. This would make sure that we do not overestimate or underestimate project costs. Another function of this office is to ensure that we do post-award monitoring to ensure that we achieve value for money in terms of quality, speed of delivery, and achieving a low-cost programme.

Mr Speaker, the President also indicated that the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026, as he has instructed the Minister for Finance to expedite action on, will also look at post-contract completion, monitoring, evaluation, and learning procedures. This will ensure that we achieve value for money. Mr Speaker, we are going to ensure, as the President indicated, that if the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026, is considered and approved by the House, procurement and financial irregularities will be addressed. These are all strategies to save money to run the 2026 fiscal year effectively.

Mr Speaker, the President did not end there. He went on to assure Ghanaians that we are not going to maintain the fiscal discipline only, but another way of making the economy run effectively is to make sure that these procurement irregularities, when addressed through the Value for Money Office Bill, 2026 will save a lot of money for us. Mr Speaker, I think last week we heard that Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) has retrieved over GH¢600 million through fraudulent transactions over the years. Mr Speaker, with GH¢600 million, if we want to construct one six-classroom block with ancillary facilities, we will be looking at approximately GH¢3 million, which means we can do about 200 units of six-unit classroom blocks across Ghana.

Mr Speaker, we will not end here. Even the President went ahead to mention the fact that there is good news for the guys operating on the offshore Cape Three Point, ENI, and VITOL. Our almighty Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), a major stakeholder in the offshore Cape Three Point, has received some good news. And so, as indicated by the President, Ghanaians are happy, and then other major stakeholders are happy. We will make sure that we stick to the statement—and, Mr Speaker, I want to reiterate this. The presentation made by the President was in line with the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy

that was presented by the Minister for Finance some time last year. So, adherence is very important to all the policy statements and our economic reforms. This will help us to implement the 2026 policies and reforms with discipline. [*Hear! Hear!*]

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much, all the debaters for today. We have come to the end of today's debate. You have all done well. Hopefully, we will continue tomorrow on the debate. Leadership, let me come to you.

**Mr Dafeamekpor:** Mr Speaker, indeed, let us commend Members for their presence on the Floor and those who made their comments towards the President's Statement. We will continue tomorrow. Mr Speaker, it is 8:15 p.m., and we have done more than five hours, so we are entirely in your hands in this matter.

**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Minority Leadership?

**Mr Fokuo:** Mr Speaker, same from our Side.

## ADJOURNMENT

*The House was adjourned at 8:15 p.m. till Wednesday, 4<sup>th</sup> March, 2026, at 2:00 p.m.*

### **Editor's Note**

This *Official Report* was adopted by the House on 11<sup>th</sup> March, 2026.